

Songs of Ourselves Volume 1

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Overview

For Paper 1, Section A of your CIE IGCSE Literature in English exams in 2026 and 2027, you will study one of the clusters of 15 poems from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology.

This page includes:

- A complete list of the poems in the cluster
- A brief overview of what is required in the exam
- A brief explanation of some of the key themes
- Top tips for the highest grade

Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 poems

The following 15 poems from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology will be assessed in 2026 and 2027:

Title	Poet
'Song: Love Armed'	Aphra Behn
'A Different History'	Sujata Bhatt
'The Chimney-Sweeper'	William Blake
'Where I Come From'	Elizabeth Brewster
'Report to Wordsworth'	Boey Kim Cheng
'Lament'	Gillian Clarke
'The Cockroach'	Kevin Halligan
'Follower'	Seamus Heaney
'Storyteller'	Liz Lochhead
'Before the Sun'	Charles Mungoshi
'A Married State'	Katherine Philips
From 'An Essay on Man'	Alexander Pope
'Carpet-weavers, Morocco'	Carol Rumens
'Sonnet 18'	William Shakespeare
'Hunting Snake'	Judith Wright

Overview

In Paper 1, Section A, you will have a choice of two questions on your studied cluster; you only answer **one** of these questions. Each question will be based on one of the 15 poems in the anthology you have studied and you will have a copy of the full poem printed on the exam paper.

Remember that there are questions on clusters other than the one you have studied, so be sure to pick the right one.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

CIE Literature in English examiners say that the best responses to the Paper 1 poetry question show a "sustained personal and evaluative engagement". A sustained answer would include a thorough analysis: aim to write a brief introduction, at least three paragraphs and a concise conclusion.

However, there's more to it than the quantity of your writing. A "personal and evaluative engagement" means that you'll need to spend time thinking about the poem overall, rather than analysing line by line. Evaluative answers begin by engaging with the key words of the question.

Key themes

Love and relationships

Ideas on love and relationships, including family love, unrequited love, and marriage, are explored in some of these poems, often presenting alternative perspectives on universal ideas. This key theme includes:

- Family love, such as in Seamus Heaney's 'Follower':
 - Rites of passage are portrayed through the description of a typical experience of a grown child moving out of the family home
- Unrequited love, such as in Aphra Behn's 'Song: Love Armed':
 - Love is exposed for its cruel, destructive nature as it is portrayed as a weapon
- Romantic relationships are examined in Katherine Philips' ironic poem 'A Married State'
- In Sonnet 18, Shakespeare describes a perfect love, one that goes beyond temporary and superficial motives

Humans and nature

The examination of the relationship between humans and nature is found in these poems:

- Judith Wright's poem 'Hunting Snake' considers how the beauty and power of a snake evokes wonder as well as fear in humans
- Environmental destruction is explored in Gillian Clarke's poem 'Lament':
 - The poem offers a different perspective on war, describing the ecological crisis caused by the Gulf War in 1991
- Paying tribute to Romantic concerns about the Industrial Revolution, Boey Kim Cheng's poem 'Report to Wordsworth' offers readers a dramatic warning
- Harmony between humans and nature is described in Charles Mungoshi's poem 'Before the Sun', in which a young boy feels a connection with his environment

Individual and cultural identity

Some of the poems criticise exploitation by showing powerless individuals in their environments, while other poems reflect on how individuals rise above their circumstances and find comfort in cultural traditions.

- The influence of tradition, language and history in shaping one's cultural identity is described in Sujata Bhatt's poem 'A Different History':
 - Bhatt explores the effects of colonialism in India on individual and communal identity
- Romantic poet William Blake criticises the imbalance of power in Victorian England in 'The Chimney-Sweeper' from his collection *Songs of Experience*:
 - The poem depicts the experiences of a young chimney-sweep, suggesting his society destroys innocence through its exploitative and faithless nature
- Similarly, Carol Rumens' poem 'Carpet-weavers' explores child labour by depicting a cultural tradition: carpet-weaving in Morocco
- Kevin Halligan's 'The Cockroach' explores the human experience using an insect to represent the chaos of human life
- Alexander Pope's 'Essay on Man' extract reflects on similar ideas: the human struggle for meaning and order in a chaotic world
- Elizabeth Brewster's poem, 'Where I Come From', reflects on how our environments shape us as individuals by contrasting rural and urban settings
- The power of oral tradition is depicted in the poem 'Storyteller' by Liz Lochhead



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners say some candidates are clearly spending too much time on their first response (the poetry question). This could affect a student's marks across the whole paper, as it may mean they spend less time than necessary on Section B, the prose question.

As each question is worth an equal 25 marks, it's a good idea to divide your time equally. Aim to spend about 45 minutes on each question.

Remember, examiners don't want you to simply unload all the information you know about the poem, instead focus on answering the question.

Top tips for the highest grade

- Quoting lines from the poem and explaining their meaning is not considered analysis:
 - Instead, explore how the poet makes decisions about language
 - Use linguistic terms to explain the effect on the reader
 - Closely relate your analysis to the question
- Write about how the poet uses patterns of language, tone of voice through rhythm and rhyme, and how endings present ideas

- Including historical facts or biographical information about the poet does not add value to your answers:
 - 'Context' is rewarded whenever you explore ideas about theme
 - Points about societal values should be linked to the writer's purpose
- To engage with the question and respond with a personal interpretation, start by focusing on key words in the question:
 - If the question uses words such as "moving", "disturbing" or "memorable" this indicates a particular focus
 - High achieving responses specifically examine techniques that create such effects
 - For example: "Sensory imagery, like 'Smothered by the smog' and 'sky slowing like a dying clock', creates a disturbing setting"
- Using the poet's name keeps you thinking the text as a conscious construct, which means you focus on how the poet made choices when creating the poem:
 - Use connectives to link your ideas to present a coherent argument

Sources

<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/646848-june-2023-examiner-report.pdf>.

"Cambridge IGCSE (9-1) 0992 Literature in English syllabus for examination in 2026." Cambridge International Education, <https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/697264-2026-syllabus.pdf>. Accessed 6 August 2025.

Songs of Ourselves: Volume 1: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Poetry in English. Cambridge University Press & Assessment, 2018.



'Song: Love Armed'

Here you will find a detailed guide to Aphra Behn's poem 'Song: Love Armed', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line "translation" of the poem's meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods:** an exploration of Behn's poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Behn's poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Behn's intention and message

'Song: Love Armed' overview

Aphra Behn, a Restoration poet and dramatist, subverts traditional ideals of romantic love in her poem 'Song: Love Armed', taken from her 1676 revenge play *Abdelazer; or, the Moor's Revenge*. The play opens with this song playing. In the song (or poem), the speaker describes love as a destructive force by representing it as a warrior, gloating over the "bleeding hearts" he has conquered.

'Song: Love Armed' breakdown

Lines 1–2



"Love in fantastic triumph sat,
Whilst bleeding hearts around him flowed,"

Translation

- The poet uses [personification](#) to describe "Love" sitting in victory or "triumph"
- At the same time, its victims, represented by "bleeding hearts", flow like blood around "him"

Behn's intentions

- Behn's poem begins with an [extended metaphor](#) alluding to a classical, god-like figure:
 - The personification of "Love" helps portray it as a cold-hearted conqueror
 - The verb "sat" portrays "Love" as on a throne, looking upon his victories
- Behn represents victims of love as wounded in the [metaphor](#) "bleeding hearts":
 - This is a play on the phrase "bleeding hearts", connoting sentimentality
 - The verb "flowed" uses [imagery](#) to describe many victims

Lines 3–4



"For whom fresh pains he did create,
And strange tyrannic power he showed:"

Translation

- The speaker refers to the "bleeding hearts", the conquests of "Love"
- They say that "Love" is a surreal ("strange") tyrant who enjoys bringing pain

Behn's intentions

- Behn portrays the powerful impact of love, and suggests individuals who are not loved in return are subjected to abuse:
 - Behn describes unrequited love as gloating and sadistic through emotive language, "fresh pains" and "tyrannic power"
- Iambic tetrameter slows the speaker's voice, creating a melodramatic effect:
 - This presents unrequited love negatively, and romantic love cynically

Lines 5–8



"From thy bright eyes he took his fire,
Which round about in sport he hurled;
But 'twas from mine he took desire,
Enough to undo the amorous world"

Translation

- The speaker describes their loved one with "bright eyes" that allowed love to throw ("hurled") fiery looks which were delivered in "sport", like a game or a competition
- Conversely, the ignored lover's eyes show only desire, so much it would "undo" (unsettle) the world of love

Behn's intentions

- Behn portrays unrequited love as one-sided and imbalanced:
 - The conjunction "But" separates two contrasting statements that describe the emotion seen in one's eyes
- The description "bright eyes" alludes to the good looks of their loved one, and that 'love' uses this to create its "fire" which, in turn, burns anyone who looks upon him
- Behn's metaphor is surreal, with phrases like "amorous world" exaggerating the mystical nature of love

Lines 9–12



"From me he took his sighs and tears,
From thee his pride and cruelty;
From me his languishments and fears,
And every killing dart from thee."

Translation

- Stanza two begins with a continued list of how "Love" enjoys bringing pain:
 - The speaker says 'Love' is proud of the pain "he" causes, and revels in the "cruelty" of the speaker's loved one killing them with metaphorical "darts"
 - From the ignored speaker, however, "Love" gains their "sighs and tears", "languishments" (despair), and "fears"

Behn's intentions

- The stark contrast between those that love and those that are loved continues in [anaphora](#) alternating between "From me" and "From thee"
- Behn repeats the idea of "Love" as a conqueror taking things without thought:
 - The line "he took" is followed by the repeated pronoun "his", which even refers to the speaker's own "languishments and fears", as if 'he' owns that too
 - Behn uses plurals, such as "fears", to suggest multiple conquests
 - This subverts a typical [allusion](#) of the Roman figure of love Cupid, the son of Venus (goddess of Love) and Mars, god of war
 - Cupid, a child who shoots arrows of love, appears here as a warrior

Lines 13–16



"Thus thou and I the God have armed,
And set him up a deity;
But my poor heart alone is harmed,
Whilst thine the victor is, and free."

Translation

- The poem ends with a conclusion, "Thus": the speaker and their loved one have made love into a "God" or a "deity" that has "armed" them both
- However, it is only the speaker's "heart" that has been injured, while the heart of the one they love is the "victor" (he has won), and remains "free"

Behn's intentions

- Behn's conclusive ending implies that love places all humans into an imaginary war
- By giving love so much attention, Behn summarises, we create a "God" of the concept, implying love holds too much power over humans:
 - This subverts traditional sentimental ideals of romantic love as sacred
- Behn is clear about unrequited love: it is a battle in which only one is hurt and there is only one winner



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Sometimes a writer's choice of structure and form overlap in terms of the effect or meaning they create. In your response to the poetry question, it is best to start your paragraphs with a point of analysis (an interpretation), such as "Behn subverts traditional ideals of romantic love." Then, support this statement with a close exploration of how aspects of form and/or structure and/or language reveal the speaker's attitudes. Follow this with an explanation of why Behn may be trying to cause this effect, and what her purpose is. Remember, keep it related to the question.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Behn's intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

The poem is written as a song, so it has two regular stanzas, each of eight lines, and follows a disciplined rhythm of alternating rhyming lines.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
The reality of love	The poem alternates between a consistent alternating rhyme scheme of ABABCD CD to EFEFGF GF in the second stanza	Behn creates a regular, sing-song rhythm that elevates traditional themes of romantic love
	The poem's 16 lines are written in iambic tetrameter to give a steady beat, although small variations appear throughout the poem	The simple form, but with variations, subverts the idea of a traditional "Cupid" version of the idea of love

Structure

Behn's poem is structured as two stanzas that generally follow a steady, slow-paced rhythm which presents the ideas in the poem as serious, as well as unsettling.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Unrequited Love	iambic tetrameter, with most lines ending with punctuated pauses, creates a solemn tone	The speaker conveys the repressed agony and sense of powerlessness caused by unrequited love, portrayed through the slow paced, steady voice
Classical, traditional love	Some lines alter the rhythm, such as the first line "Love in Fantastic Triumph sat", which uses a trochee	Behn subverts traditional ideals of romantic love with the cynical tone that begins the poem

Language

Behn's extended metaphor makes use of a classical allusion to present the idea of love as a powerful and tyrannical warrior who takes pleasure in causing heartbreak.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
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Unrequited love	The poem employs imagery related to injury: emotive language like "fresh pains", "tears", and "poor heart" describes how the speaker has been harmed	Behn's speaker is presented as a victim of unrequited love through the personal, intimate expression of their physical and emotional pain
Classical, traditional love	The personification of love as a powerful and cruel god of war is continued throughout the poem	Behn draws attention to the destructive side of love in an hyperbolic allusion that challenges traditional ideas of romance

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore the writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes explored by Behn in 'Song: Love Armed':

- Unrequited love
- Classical, traditional ideas of love



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward an answer that responds "sensitively and in considerable detail" to the way the writer achieves their effects. This means you should explore the poem beyond surface meanings to show deeper awareness of ideas and attitudes. While knowing about the kind of poetry associated with classical literature, or society's values in Aphra Behn's time regarding love and gender, will help you understand ideas in the poem, your points should always be closely linked to the themes in the poem.

Unrequited love

- Aphra Behn wrote during the Restoration period, a time when literature began to explore realism and **satire**:
 - 'Song: Love Armed' subverts traditional notions of sentimental, romantic love, and icons such as Cupid, to present love as unkind and omnipotent
 - Love is satirised as a greedy, god-like tyrant, a more cynical and realistic portrayal of unrequited love than contemporary poems of perfect love
- Unrequited love, a common theme in poetry at the time, explores complex relationships, such as those found within the court of King Charles II and during the Restoration period more generally
- While Behn wrote at a time when female dramatists and poets were few, the Restoration period encouraged freedom from the Puritanism of previous years:
 - In Behn's poetry, the speaker is almost always a female who expresses extreme emotions as a response to romantic and sexual relationships
 - In 'Song: Love Armed', the speaker repeatedly refers to their loved one as "he", suggesting the speaker is female

Classical, traditional love

- Aphra Behn was called "The English Sappho", a comparison to Greek poet Sappho
- Contemporary poet, Katherine Philips, was another female British poet praised for their elaborate language and lyrical quality:
 - The poem 'Song: Love Armed' is an example of this: it employs sophisticated rhythm and rhyme in a disciplined structure that mimics classical poetry
- The poem makes an allusion to a mythological Roman "God" or "Deity" who controls humans as if in a game ("sport"), a common theme of seventeenth century literature:
 - Military language such as "armed" and "victor" work alongside abstract nouns that have been capitalised, typical of classical literature

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/646848-june-2023-examiner-report.pdf>.

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'A Different History'

Here is a detailed guide to Sujata Bhatt's poem 'A Different History' from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line "translation" of the poem's meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods:** an exploration of Bhatt's poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Bhatt's poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Bhatt's intention and message

'A Different History' overview

Like many of Sujata Bhatt's poems, 'A Different History' examines the idea of diaspora and the conflict between her Indian heritage and life in the English-speaking world. The poem describes traditional Indian values related to Hinduism, and considers the influence of English as a result of British imperialism. She places emphasis on the positive aspects of her own culture and traditions.

'A Different History' breakdown

Lines 1–3



"Great Pan is not dead;
he simply emigrated
to India."

Translation

- The poem begins by stating that "Great Pan", a classical god of the wilderness and fertility, is alive and has moved to India:
 - Pan's death symbolises the end of paganism as Christianity spread
 - The reference to Pan's death alludes to a line written by Greek philosopher Plutarch: "the great god Pan is dead"

Bhatt's intentions

- Bhatt introduces themes of heritage and culture by implying a "Great" god of nature has chosen India which, she suggests, is ironic
 - Bhatt's **allusion** to mythological figure "Pan" is placed next to the **litotes** of "simply emigrated" and indented line "to India" to suggest this is unexpected

Lines 4–6



"Here, the gods roam freely,
disguised as snakes or monkeys;
every tree is sacred"

Translation

- The speaker explains why the "Great Pan" has moved to India
- There, the gods are free to wander ("roam") around disguised as animals and trees, because in India nature is respected and considered holy

Bhatt's intentions

- Bhatt highlights aspects of Indian culture that, she says, contrast with the West:
 - She refers to Hindu gods that are in the shape of "snakes" and "monkeys", using **imagery** that relates to harmony and freedom, like "roam freely"
- Bhatt separates the phrase "every tree is sacred" to highlight the deep respect for nature and equality as an overarching ideology in traditional India

Lines 7–14



"and it is a sin
to be rude to a book.
It is a sin to shove a book aside
with your foot,
a sin to slam books down
hard on a table,
a sin to toss one carelessly
across a room."

Translation

- The speaker shifts to a list of traditional Hindu rules about books:
 - It is a "sin" to disrespect books or treat them "carelessly"

Bhatt's intentions

- Bhatt uses enjambment and the conjunction "and" to connect books and nature and to show their similar prominence in Indian culture and the Hindu religion:
 - Bhatt emphasises this idea with a list, as if reciting from scripture
- Bhatt's **juxtaposition** of religious language with informal verbs like "shove" and "toss" blends tradition with modernity, presenting a speaker unconcerned with rules

Lines 15–18



"You must learn how to turn the pages gently
without disturbing Sarasvati,
without offending the tree
from whose wood the paper was made."

Translation

- Bhatt ends the first stanza giving the reader an instruction:
 - It is important to be careful with books as they are made from "sacred" trees
- She explains that damaging a book could "offend" the tree from which it was made, or disturb "Sarasvati" (the Hindu goddess of learning and knowledge)

Bhatt's intentions

- In a direct address, Bhatt presents ancient traditional values as a certainty with the modal verb "must", perhaps suggesting all cultures have strict rules
- Bhatt describes the significance of nature and knowledge within Hinduism:
 - **Personification** is applied to trees in these lines as it was previously to books: one should not be "rude to a book" nor "offend" a tree

Lines 19–22



"Which language
has not been the oppressor's tongue?
Which language
truly meant to murder someone?"

Translation

- The second stanza begins with the speaker asking two questions:
 - Bhatt asks the reader if all language ("tongue") is used to oppress
 - Her second question implies language itself does not intend harm ("murder") through the emphasis of "truly"

Bhatt's intentions

- Bhatt's dramatic shift in focus presents the connection between, and the influence of, language and imperialism as she interrogates language and violence

- The repeated questions highlight “oppressor’s tongue” and “murder” which introduces darker ideas regarding colonialism

Lines 23–29



“And how does it happen
that after the torture,
after the soul has been cropped
with a long scythe swooping out
of the conqueror’s face –
the unborn grandchildren
grow to love that strange language.”

Translation

- The final lines are one long sentence: it considers how the “strange” English language could be so loved by India’s “unborn grandchildren”
- The line reflects on “torture” inflicted by the “conqueror’s face” (Imperial Britain):
 - It describes how natives experienced violence: a “long scythe” refers to tools which, Bhatt says, “cropped” or ‘cut’ down the Indian identity

Bhatt’s intentions

- A seven line sentence conveys Bhatt’s overwhelming frustration with India’s continued love for English, a language which once suppressed her native country:
 - Bhatt connotes to violent imperialism by describing a powerful “conqueror”
- Bhatt ends the poem as she begins it, with bitter **irony**: “And how does it happen”
- The sentence is phrased as a question, but posed as a statement to imply an irreversible, yet “strange”, truth:
 - Language can be used to oppress, but it is not responsible in itself, and this is why India’s “unborn” generations continue to love it



Examiner Tips and Tricks

A good start to writing a “personal and evaluative engagement” is to engage with the key words of the question and think carefully about your introduction. Examiners have highlighted some key issues with introductions:

- Writing lengthy introductions with biographical or historical facts that are unrelated to the question or linked to writer’s purpose “delays” your answer
- Writing about themes not directly related to the question limits your overall grade
- Starting with a list of the devices used by the poet is not “productive”

In other words, your introduction should set up a clear argument that focuses on the writer’s purposes and, of course, engages with the specific question asked.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered “writer’s methods” in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet’s choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

The exam question requires you to **focus on the deeper ideas in the poem** so, instead of simply identifying techniques or translating quotes, **explore how the poet’s decisions** reveal a **theme**. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Bhatt’s intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Bhatt’s **free verse** form follows an irregular rhythm to present a thoughtful, yet irreverent speaker who debates the power of language and its part in the suppression of cultural identity.

Theme	Evidence	Poet’s intention
Cultural identity	The poem lacks rhyme or consistent rhythm, but it uses assonance (“freely” and “monkeys”) and sibilance (“disturbing Sarasvati”) to create a lyrical quality	Bhatt evokes a sense of harmony in parts of the poem that deal with Hindu and Indian values relating to humans, nature and books

Individual identity	However, this changes when lines are irregularly indented to present a flippant speaker, such as in lines 1–3	Bhatt alters the speaker's tone to sardonically interrogate the power of language to oppress
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Structure

Bhatt's poem is made up of two irregular stanzas that shift between narrative perspective, and the poet varies the tones of voice to create an unpredictable reflection on cultural identity and challenge accepted ideas.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	The poem's stanzas develop different ideas: initially, a calm speaker describes classical and Indian culture and religion, but stanza 2 introduces a second person voice that bitterly questions the reader	Bhatt's poem refers to mythology, Hinduism, and post-colonial attitudes in a rambling, irregular poem that conveys cultural tensions and contrasts
	The poet uses parallelism to give the speaker's language a thoughtful pace. For example, the repetition of "it is a sin"	This evokes a stern warning to the reader to emphasise the power of respecting a culture and its traditions

Language

Bhatt's poem employs classical allusion and informal language to present cultural tensions, especially between the past and the future. Alongside this, persuasive language presents an argument about the power of language.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem employs anaphora in "it is a sin" to highlight religious language, as well as in "Which language" which questions the violence of a "conqueror's face" who cuts down metaphorical 'souls' with a "swooping" "scythe"	Bhatt uses persuasive language to debate the impact of language in religion, as well as in forms of oppression such as British colonialism
Cultural identity	Bhatt juxtaposes classical and traditional allusion with informal verbs like "shove" and "toss"	Bhatt presents themes of history and modernity by embedding ancient references and metaphor in a contemporary debate on the English language and its popularity with India's "unborn grandchildren"

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that it is **not enough** just to **know the poem**, but that you will also need to develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events** to explore the **writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes that Bhatt explores in 'A Different History':

- Cultural identity
- Individual identity



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward answers that respond "sensitively and in considerable detail" to the way the writer achieves their effects. You are being asked to explore the poem beyond surface meanings to show deeper awareness of ideas and attitudes. While knowing about the Hindu religion or British colonisation of India will help you understand debates Bhatt raises, your points should be closely linked to the themes in the poem and relevant to the focus of the question.

Cultural identity

- Sujata Bhatt was born in Gujarat, India, in 1956, and moved to America with her family in 1968, which is perhaps why she calls her poetry "Indian-English":
 - 'A Different History' highlights her native culture by referring to Hindu gods, and the respect and harmony between humans and nature
 - She mentions "Sarasvati" and, by implication, Hanuman, monkey god of wisdom, and snakes that may belong to gods Shiva and Vishnu
 - But, alongside this, she uses informal English like "toss" and "shove"

Individual identity

- India became a colony under British rule in the nineteenth century, amidst much turmoil
- In 'A Different History', the English language is described as the "oppressor's tongue", alluding to its continued prominence in India:

- Bhatt describes successive generations speaking English in the final lines that mention "unborn grandchildren" who love the "strange" language
- Bhatt's poem 'A Different History' was part of her 1988 debut collection 'Brunizem':
 - The title refers to a kind of soil found in India, suggesting that Bhatt's work has a deep connection to her roots
 - The poem considers the way English is used to suppress and overpower, and wonders at the love for it, but concludes that language itself is not to blame

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

"Cambridge IGCSE (9–1) 0992 Literature in English syllabus for examination in 2026." Cambridge International Education, <https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/697264-2026-syllabus.pdf>. Accessed 6 August 2025.

Songs of Ourselves: Volume 1: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Poetry in English. Cambridge University Press & Assessment, 2018.

‘The Chimney-Sweeper’

Here is a detailed guide to William Blake’s ‘The Chimney-Sweeper’ from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods:** an exploration of Blake’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of themes and ideas within Blake’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Blake’s intention and message

‘The Chimney-Sweeper’ overview

William Blake’s ‘The Chimney-Sweeper’ is part of his collection of poems: Songs of Innocence and Experience. Like many in this collection, the poem depicts a child experiencing fear and distress. In this way, Blake connects social repression with the loss of innocence.

‘The Chimney-Sweeper’ breakdown

Lines 1–2



“A little black thing among the snow,
Crying ‘weep, ‘weep, in notes of woe!”

Translation

- The poem begins with a present-tense description of a child covered in “black” soot:
 - The small child cries in sounds full of “woe” (sadness and despair)

Blake’s intentions

- Blake begins with a contrast of “black” and “white” to convey opposing ideas:
 - This highlights oppositions like the purity of youth and dark, evil experience
- The child is almost unrecognisable as human by the sheer amount of soot covering him:
 - This has the effect of dehumanising him; he is literally and **metaphorically** unidentifiable — a mere black shape and a dark mark on society’s conscience
- The child is presented as a desperate victim, a “little” suffering “thing”, to introduce the idea of child neglect:
 - Here, the reader becomes a spectator to the child’s suffering, and is therefore complicit in it

Lines 3–4



“Where are thy father and mother, say?
‘They are both gone up to the church to pray.’”

Translation

- The poem introduces **dialogue**: an unknown speaker asks where the child’s parents are, and is told they have gone to church

Blake’s intentions

- Dialogue, a common technique in Romantic poetry, helps Blake show realistic human experiences and expressions of emotion, such as the depictions of suffering in this case
- Blake thus introduces his criticism of a hypocritical society:
 - He implies that the parents appear to be respectable Christians, but they have left their child alone and cold

Lines 5–8



"'Because I was happy upon the heath
And smiled among the winter's snow,
They clothed me in the clothes of death
And taught me to sing the notes of woe.'"

Translation

- The child speaker explains the reasons they have been left alone in "clothes of death" (connoting to the clothes of a chimney-sweeper):
 - The child was "happy" and smiled even in the "snow", but adults decided to send them to work, which "taught" them to sing sad songs instead

Blake's intentions

- Blake contrasts a happy child with one whose innocence has been taken:
 - He links the freedom of nature to happiness: the child smiled in the "winter's snow" and was "happy" on the "heath"
 - This is contrasted with a child sent to work in "clothes of death", connoting to the short lives of chimney-sweepers as a result of poor work conditions
- The child's parents may represent seemingly responsible Christians in Blake's society:
 - This places the blame for the child's suffering not only on the parents, but also on organised religion

Lines 9–10



"'And because I am happy and dance and sing,
They think they have done me no injury:'"

Translation

- The child speaker, clear about what has happened, adds that because they are naturally happy adults think they have done no harm by allowing child labour to continue

Blake's intentions

- In a poignant line, Blake shows the innocence of children who endure suffering
- Blake alludes to the ignorance of his peers and the Church by implying they do not understand these children and spend little time considering their plight

Lines 11–12



"'And are gone to praise God and his priest and king,
Who make up a heaven of our misery.'"

Translation

- The last lines of the poem revisit the idea of the child being abandoned and having no one to look after them
- The child speaker takes on a more experienced, adult voice in the final statement that those who say they are religious actually fail in their moral duties

Blake's intentions

- Blake concludes with a **metaphor** that represents a key criticism of his society:
 - Despite responsible adults' Christian duties, they have lost sight of moral values
 - A now cynical child speaker lists "God and priest and king" as behind their isolation and suffering
 - The irony of the reference to "heaven" is that it is meant to be a place of happiness and freedom, but organised religion offers only a "heaven of our misery"



Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes and, specifically, the "deeper meanings of the poem".

Examiners advise you to spend more time thinking about, for example, the reason Blake uses a child to criticise his society, or why he chose a particular rhythm. To achieve a convincing analysis, mentioning rhyme should develop into an exploration of why this has been used to recreate a child's innocent voice.

The word "why" has been used a lot in this paragraph. That's because analysis means asking why a writer has created a certain effect and what ideas are conveyed as a result.



Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Blake's intentions in terms of his choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Blake's poem 'The Chimney-Sweeper' portrays the loss of a child's innocence, which is why a large part of the poem is spoken by a child speaker. Blake's simple, regular form directly contrasts with the horrifying and bleak conditions of the child chimney sweep.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Innocence and experience	The poem follows a regular rhyme scheme that mimics the sound of a nursery rhyme	The speaker is singing the "notes of woe", making the poem a song of the child's misery, contrasting the innocence of childhood with the neglect and trauma the chimney sweep experiences
	The poem is mostly written in iambic tetrameter and rhyming couplets to create a steady, sing-song rhythm that connotes to childhood	

Structure

Blake follows a simple structure, again to contrast sharply with the subject matter.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intentions
Innocence and experience	The poem is made up of three regular stanzas which include dialogue that becomes a child speaker's monologue	The steady simplicity of the lines juxtapose the innocent child's increasing cynicism as he explains his tragic circumstances
	The poet unsettles the nursery rhyme quality of the poem with exclamatory lines that break the steady rhythm, such as "weep, weep, in notes of woe"	While the poem alludes to the simplicity of innocent youth, the inconsistencies present the child's distress

Language

Blake aims to reveal double-standards in his society, particularly regarding the established Christian church in eighteenth century England.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Attitudes to religion	The poem begins with simple language referring to religion ("gone up to the church to pray"), but this changes by the end of the poem when a metaphor , "a heaven of our misery", links "God and his priest and king" to the idea of despair	Blake criticises the Christian church in terms of their complicity in the suffering of children, and suggests the institution is hypocritical
Innocence and experience	Contrasting imagery , such as "black", "snow" and "clothes of death", is placed alongside alliterative descriptions of a dancing, singing child who is "happy" on the "heath"	The poem aims to depict a child's extreme circumstances in Victorian England by contrasting the happiness of innocence with the death and misery brought about by exploitative child labour

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore** the **writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes that Blake explores in 'The Chimney-Sweeper':

- Innocence and experience

- Attitudes to religion



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward an answer that responds “sensitively and in considerable detail” to the **way** the writer achieves their effects. You are being asked to explore the poem beyond surface meanings to show deeper awareness of ideas and attitudes. While knowing about Victorian England and Blake’s collections of poetry will help you understand the debates raised, your points must closely link to the themes in the poem, relevant to the question.



Innocence and experience

- Blake is considered a Romantic poet: his work examines the power of the imagination and nature, as well as human emotions and experiences:
 - But his poems are often politically charged and offer cynical or radical attacks on his society
 - ‘The Chimney-Sweeper’ criticises Christian parents and, more broadly, society, for ignoring and contributing to the suffering of children in eighteenth century England
- This poem, taken from Blake’s subsequent collection Songs of Innocence and Experience, focuses on the lost innocence he believes is inevitable in corrupt society:
 - In eighteenth century England, wealth imbalances led to extreme poverty
- The Industrial Revolution and its drive for profit at the expense of its workers forced lower classes into hard labour:
 - Small children, such as depicted in this poem, were employed as chimney-sweeps for the upper classes
 - Unsafe conditions and exposure to soot led to many deaths, but new children (sometimes as young as six) would be sent to replace them
 - The poem alludes to this in the line “clothes of death”
- By contrasting a “happy” child dancing on a “heath” with one crying in the “winter’s snow”, Blake asserts that innocence cannot last if one experiences injustice

Attitudes to religion

- Blake’s poetry often criticises institutions such as the Church:
 - Blake’s poem ‘The Chimney-Sweeper’ explores the neglect of children in a society that operates under the guise of abiding by Christian values
 - The child describes absent parents who are at church while he suffers alone
 - The parents represent Christians who ignore the suffering of innocents
- While Blake was a Christian himself, his views were considered radical:
 - This was predominantly because of his belief that Jesus was a revolutionary acting for social justice, and because he claimed to have visions of angels
 - Certainly, the final line in ‘The Chimney-Sweeper’ is a scathing attack on his contemporary society’s version of Christianity

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

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‘Where I Come From’

Here is a detailed guide to Elizabeth Brewster’s poem ‘Where I Come From’, which can be found in the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods:** an exploration of Brewster’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of themes and ideas within Brewster’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Brewster’s intention and message

‘Where I Come From’ overview

Elizabeth Brewster’s poem ‘Where I Come From’ examines the influence of place and environment on individual identity. It begins by explaining how sensory experiences leave an impression on people all over the world, and develops into a nostalgic memory about the speaker’s own home.

‘Where I Come From’ breakdown

Lines 1–3



“People are made of places. They carry with them
hints of jungles or mountains, a tropic grace
or the cool eyes of sea gazers. Atmosphere of cities”

Translation

- The poem begins with a statement: individual identity is shaped by environment
- It is explained that they absorb or “carry with them” aspects (“hints”) of places such as “grace” (elegance) from tropical jungles, or “cool” eyes from watching the ocean

Brewster’s intentions

- Brewster establishes the theme of the poem: individual identity is shaped by places
- She describes people with **metaphor** connoting to habitats, such as those with a “tropic grace” or eyes “cool” from the ocean:
 - This presents humans and natural environments as intrinsically linked

Lines 4–8



“how different drops from them, like the smell of smog
or the almost-not-smell of tulips in the spring,
nature tidily plotted in little squares
with a fountain in the centre; museum smell
Art also tidily plotted with a guidebook;”

Translation

- The poem describes the atmosphere of a city, with the absence of nature’s smell
- She implies the smells of a city are different, and that cities divide nature into neat squares with fountains in the middle, or like museums which organise art into neat blocks complete with a guidebook

Brewster’s intentions

- Brewster implies that the city tries to control nature:
 - The metaphorical “nature tidily plotted” describes a man-made environment

- In a city, everything has a place, suggesting the urban environment tries to control its inhabitants too and tries to restrict spontaneity and wildness
- The alliteration of "different drops" emphasises a key theme, that places leave impressions on people, no matter how different they are
- The repetition of "smell" reinforces the importance of this sense



Lines 9–11



"or the smell of work, glue factories maybe,
chromium-plated offices; smell of subways
crowded at rush hours."

Translation

- The poem focuses on the different smells of a city: "glue", steel, and subways
- These are connected to places of work, such as "factories", "offices", and commuters in subways during "rush hours"

Brewster's intentions

- Brewster uses sensory **imagery** to describe nature in an urban setting: the smell of "work" and man-made materials
- She presents city life as busy, suggesting the environment makes people feel hurried

Lines 12–17



"Where I come from, people
carry woods in their minds, acres of pine woods;
blueberry patches in the burned-out bush;
wooden farmhouses, old, in need of paint,
with yards where hens and chickens circle about
clucking aimlessly; battered schoolhouses"

Translation

- The poem moves to describing the speaker's own home: where she comes from the people have forests in their "minds", implying nature is part of their psyche or identity
- A list of descriptions of a rural location (a run-down busy farm) describe her home:
 - There are "battered schoolhouses", and hens "clucking" near "burned-out" bushes and "blueberry patches"

Brewster's intentions

- Brewster brings the focus inward as she considers how her identity has been influenced by a rural upbringing:
 - She creates a sense of bustling energy to present a happy, busy environment
 - A nostalgic tone presents memories of home as relaxed amongst nature
 - She creates a sensory contrast with the human creations previously described
- Brewster shows how past experiences of places become ingrained in memory

Lines 18–19



"behind which violets grow. Spring and winter
are the mind's chief seasons: ice and the breaking of ice."

Translation

- The poet states that it is the seasons of winter and spring that are most remembered ("the mind's chief seasons")
- It is the ice forming and breaking that makes these seasons so memorable

Brewster's intentions

- Brewster describes memories that suggest the impact of one's heritage on identity
- The repetition of "ice" implies memories of home centre around sensual feeling

Lines 20–21



"A door in the mind blows open, and there blows
a frosty wind from fields of snow."



Translation

- The last lines of the poem describe memory as a "door in the mind":
 - In the speaker's memory it is like they can feel the "frosty wind" again

Brewster's intentions

- Brewster's poem portrays how memories can be triggered by weather and habitat:
 - A metaphor symbolises memory as a "door" to the past
 - Brewster uses the word "mind" here, and elsewhere in the poem, to connect place with thought
- Repetition of "blow" presents memory as an intense and with a sudden "frosty wind"



Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for the poetry question in CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes. Specifically, examiners reward a personal engagement with the poem's "deeper meanings". This means you should spend more time thinking about, for example, the reason Brewster describes two different settings in her poem. Ask yourself **why** the poet has created a certain effect, and what ideas are conveyed as a result.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Brewster's intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Brewster's poem is a reflection on how places influence individuals; particularly how they form part of our identity as they become memories.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intentions
Humans and nature	The poem, made up of three irregular stanzas, progresses a reader through a reflection on varied settings: the first stanza examines the world and cities, while the second and third stanzas become a personal recollection of the speaker's rural home	Brewster's poem is, initially, an examination of how environments affect individuals, especially in the chaos of city life, but its subjective ending about a past life reveals a speaker caught up in their own memories of a significant place, as if to prove her point

Structure

Brewster's poem is informal with no pattern of **metre** or **rhyme**, which contributes to its reflective subject matter about memories of places, and the impressions they leave on individuals.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem is a rambling reflection that uses enjambment and a conversational style to present an unplanned exploration of place and identity	Brewster's unpredictable and chaotic style contributes to the idea that individual identity is shaped by random sensory experiences which trigger the memories of places

Language

Brewster describes places through sensory experiences, such as smell, texture, colour, and weather to show how places become ingrained in the minds of inhabitants of the world, and therefore shape individual identity.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	Using sibilance the poet emphasises the intensity of city life ("smell of smog"), which is contrasted with a vibrant image of rural life that includes extremes such as "violets" and "ice" while simultaneously portraying it as a relaxed lifestyle through onomatopoeia like "clucking aimlessly"	Brewster suggests that city life is intense, and shapes us in terms of career, whereas rural places offer a simpler life and are part of our heritage
Individual identity	Sensory imagery describes the intense impressions of places on people: smells such as "glue", textures like "chromium-plated offices", weather like "a frosty wind", or colours like "blueberry"	Brewster implies that memories and identities are formed from the sensory nature of places we live in

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore** the **writer's intentions and methods**.

This section has been divided into two main themes that Brewster explores in 'Where I Come From':

- Urban and rural settings
- Individual identity



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners ask for a "personal and evaluative engagement". The best way to achieve this is to engage with the key words of the question, and think carefully about your introduction. It is a good idea to avoid beginning with biographical or historical facts about the poet or the time in which the poem was written, unless you link it to how the poet covers this as a theme. You could write, for instance: "Brewster explores how memories shape individual identity in her personal poem, and reflects on her own Canadian heritage in her description of a cold and rural setting".

Humans and nature

- Elizabeth Brewster, born in 1922, grew up in a rural Canadian logging town
- The poem 'Where I Come From' appears in her 1977 book *Sometimes I Think of Moving*, which covers themes of place, often about her home in New Brunswick:
 - In this poem, Brewster emphasises a cold setting with the repetition of "ice and the breaking of ice", and a final line "frosty wind from fields of snow"
 - The rural setting which she describes as her childhood home portrays a wilderness of "acres of pine"

Individual identity

- Brewster is considered a modernist poet whose work focuses on landscapes and environments, and how personal heritage shapes individual identity
- Her poetry often employs conversational speakers who use simple imagery:
 - The poem 'Where I Come From' uses simple descriptions, such as "burned-out bush" or "breaking of ice"
 - Simple metaphor such as "cool eyes" maintains a simplistic style
- The influence of other modernist poets may be found in Brewster's unpredictable, rambling structure that follows no regular rhythm or rhyme

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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‘Report to Wordsworth’

Here is a detailed guide to Boey Kim Cheng’s poem ‘Report to Wordsworth’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods:** an exploration of Cheng’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Cheng’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Boey Kim Cheng’s intention and message

‘Report to Wordsworth’ overview

Boey Kim Cheng’s poem offers a modern perspective on Romantic ideals about nature. The poem is an interaction between the poet, William Wordsworth, and a speaker who reports from a grim modern world in which the natural world has been destroyed, as Wordsworth warned.

‘Report to Wordsworth’ breakdown

Line 1



“You should be here, Nature has need of you.”

Translation

- The speaker immediately addresses the English nature-poet, William Wordsworth, as “You”
- He reports that the natural world needs Wordsworth, and he should be “here” (in the present day)

Cheng’s intentions

- Boey Kim Cheng begins with an **apostrophe** to convey the seriousness of the issue:
 - The speaker calls upon Wordsworth to assist the modern world with its urgent environmental crisis
- Cheng alludes to Romantic poetry to draw attention to how the same problems exist in the present day: that of human connection with nature in an advancing world

Lines 2–4



“She has been laid waste. Smothered by the smog,
the flowers are mute, and the birds are few
in a sky slowing like a dying clock.”

Translation

- The speaker says that Nature (“She”) has been destroyed and left bare
- This is because the “smog” has sucked the air from living things
- The flowers are silent, and there are hardly any birds because the sky is “dying”

Cheng’s intentions

- Cheng **personifies** nature as a female living thing, typical of Romantic poetry
- The speaker describes the desolation of the earth using sinister sensory imagery, such as silenced flowers:
 - He alludes to a ticking clock, suggesting that time is running out

Lines 5–10





"All hopes of Proteus rising from the sea
have sunk; he is entombed in the waste
we dump. Triton's notes struggle to be free,
his famous horns are choked, his eyes are dazed,
and Neptune lies helpless as beached as a whale,
while insatiate man moves in for the kill."



Your notes

Translation

- The speaker describes various mythological Greek and Roman gods of the sea:
 - "Proteus", a shape-changing sea-god, is trapped in the "waste" humans "dump" in the sea
 - "Triton", another sea-god who used shells as wind instruments, cannot make a sound, and he is "choked" and confused
 - "Neptune", Roman god of the sea, has been "beached" like a whale, exposed and vulnerable
- The speaker says these gods have been defeated by greedy humans ("insatiate man") who are hunting and preparing for a "kill"

Cheng's intentions

- Boey's **allusion** to mythological gods of the sea presents the power and timelessness of nature, but the imagery describes a polluted and toxic modern sea:
 - The informal use of "dump" creates a cynical tone
- Boey blames greedy humans for the destruction of nature, and the oppression of spirituality

Lines 11–12



"Poetry and piety have begun to fail,
as Nature's mighty heart is lying still."

Translation

- The poem begins to come to a conclusion: the values expressed in Romantic poetry, and any sense of respect ("piety") for the environment, have failed
- The speaker says that nature, a powerful being, has been killed

Cheng's intentions

- The poem is a dramatic lament to past poets who encouraged a respect for nature:
 - The things that once inspired and sustained us have failed
- The power of nature is emphasised in order to show how dangerous humans are to have been able to kill nature's "mighty heart"

Lines 13–14



"O see the widening in the sky,
God is labouring to utter his last cry."

Translation

- The poem ends with an exclamation that warns of an injured sky opening up to reveal a struggling God who is about to cry for the final time

Cheng's intentions

- Cheng's poem mimics Wordsworth's poetry by ending with a frustrated and defeated speaker who offers a bleak conclusion about humanity
- His modern poem goes a step further as he describes a dying God, and alludes to the end of the world:
 - The damage done by humanity is so extensive that it has touched the universe's most powerful forces, including God



Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes and, specifically, the "deeper meanings of the poem". Examiners advise you to spend more time thinking about, for example, the

reason Boey Kim Cheng personifies nature in the poem 'Report to Wordsworth'. To achieve a convincing analysis, mentioning a technique should develop into an exploration of why this has been used, and the reasons the poet, for example, wants to show nature as a living being.



Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Cheng's intentions in terms of his choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

The poem 'Report to Wordsworth' is written in the form of a **sonnet**. By using a variation on a traditional love poem, Cheng suggests the earlier poetic forms of sonnets and the natural world have been altered by the modern world.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	The 14 line poem uses the form of a sonnet with a traditional rhyme scheme (ABAB CDCD EFEF GG)	Boey uses a traditional form of poetry, one connected to ideals of love, to pay tribute to classical and Romantic poetry

Structure

Boey Kim Cheng breaks traditional poetic structures in order to present a destabilised and distressed speaker who pleads to past poets in a modern lament about the destruction of the world.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	The sonnet's metre is unstable, with uneven caesura and enjambment combining to create a desperate tone of voice	Boey's speaker expresses the urgency of a slowly dying natural world and the failure of spiritual values
Cultural identity	Emphatic sentences introduce an earnest speaker who calls on William Wordsworth to save the modern world: "You should be here."	In a "report" to a past Romantic poet, Cheng makes parallels between eighteenth century concerns about the natural world and those of present day, in which the consequences of past warnings have become serious

Language

In this poem, Cheng draws on traditional and classical allusions to create tension and drama in his passionate reflection on the danger of human beings, and their reckless disrespect for the environment.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	While personification connotes to nature as a powerful living thing (such as in "Nature's mighty heart"), sibilance draws attention to imagery describing the world as "Smothered by the smog"	In a tribute to Romantic poetry, Cheng draws attention to nature and the destruction of it as a result of human advancements
Cultural identity	A simile compares the sky to a "dying clock" which connotes to time running out; this is emphasised by allusions to powerful gods struggling in a polluted and poisonous ocean, and a final warning that "God" is dying in a "wound widening" sky	Cheng makes historical and classical references in order to convey the gravity of the situation in the modern world, suggesting the eternal idea of spirituality and "God" is dying along with the natural world, a typically Romantic idea

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore the writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes that Boey Kim Cheng explores in 'Report to Wordsworth':

- Humans and nature
- Cultural identity



Examiner Tips and Tricks

When you answer the poetry question on the CIE Literature for English Paper 1, remember to link any comments you want to make on historical or social context to ideas Boey Kim Cheng wants to raise in his poem 'Report to Wordsworth'. In other words, think about how his poem may be part of a modern movement addressing climate change in the same way as Wordsworth and other Romantic poets addressed the impact of the Industrial Revolution on humans and nature.



Your notes

Humans and nature

- Boey Kim Cheng was born in Singapore in 1965, but moved to Australia as an adult
- Cheng's concern with themes of place, and the impact of environment on individuals, is addressed in a poetry collection called 'Another Place':
 - The poem 'Report to Wordsworth' appears in this collection
 - In it, Cheng highlights aspects of the climate crisis, such as the line "helpless as beached as a whale", and "the waste/we dump"
- In 'Report to Wordsworth', Cheng offers a desperate commentary on human greed and humanity's recklessness towards a natural world "laid waste":
 - The repetition of "waste" implies frustration at the needlessness of the destruction, as well as pollution
- Cheng's poem alludes to concerns expressed by Romantic poets at the time of the Industrial Revolution
- Poets such as William Wordsworth, who Cheng addresses, warned of the emotional turmoil experienced by individuals losing connection with nature:
 - As mass production increased, poets such as Wordsworth expressed a deep worry about the consequences of a world without nature
 - They warned of the damage to an individual's spirituality and imagination
 - Cheng refers to the failure of "piety" as "Nature" has been killed

Cultural identity

- Boey Kim Cheng's work is influenced by British Romantic poets
- Boey addresses the Romantic poet, William Wordsworth, in this poem, alluding to several of his poems in order to pay tribute to traditional ideas
- Wordsworth's 'London, 1802' begins: "Milton! thou shouldst be living at this hour: England hath need of thee":
 - Boey echoes Wordsworth and all classical writers, such as seventeenth century poet John Milton, in his similar first lines
 - However, his poem uses modern language, and sounds far more serious: "You should be here. Nature has need of you."
- Wordsworth's poem 'Composed upon Westminster Bridge, September 3, 1802' has the line, "mighty heart is lying still":
 - Cheng uses this metaphor to describe nature in his poem, which emphasises the worsening climate crisis
- Another of Wordsworth's poems, 'The World Is Too Much With Us', refers to Greek gods "Proteus" and "Triton", which Cheng describes dying in a polluted and toxic sea
- Boey Kim Cheng's poetry presents a modern world that has become cynical as a result of its lost connection with the natural world:
 - This poem alludes to the death of God
 - Cheng connects the past and the present to highlight continuing problems in the modern world
 - Using continuous present tense suggests the problems that have been previously ignored are immediate (the world is a "dying clock")

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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‘Lament’

Here is a detailed guide to Gillian Clarke's poem 'Lament', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line "translation" of the poem's meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods:** an exploration of Clarke's poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Clarke's poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Gillian Clarke's intention and message

‘Lament’ overview

The poem 'Lament', by Gillian Clarke, is a simple expression of grief about the circumstances of the modern world and conflict in particular. Each stanza focuses on a different consequence to show the far-reaching and damaging effects of war.

‘Lament’ breakdown

Lines 1–3



"For the green turtle with her pulsing burden,
in search of the breeding ground.
For her eggs laid in their nest of sickness."

Translation

- The poem immediately explains the poem's title by beginning with a tribute:
 - The speaker laments for a pregnant "turtle" looking for a safe place to lay her eggs
- The speaker says the nest is in a place of "sickness", perhaps implying the beach is polluted and diseased

Clarke's intentions

- Clarke's poem is presented as an [elegy](#)
- It begins with an expression of sorrow for animals like the "green turtle" who struggles to adapt to changing environmental conditions
- Immediately, Clarke introduces ideas about the natural world, and that it may be sick, [metaphorically](#) and literally

Lines 4–6



"For the cormorant in his funeral silk,
the veil of iridescence on the sand,
the shadow on the sea."

Translation

- The speaker grieves for birds, such as the cormorant
- The bird's feathers are described as black ("funeral") silk
- The speaker adds that the sand and sea are darkened by a "veil" and a "shadow":
 - But there is also "iridescence", which describes bright colours reflected in oil

Clarke's intentions

- Gillian Clarke connotes to death with [imagery](#) that implies the cormorant wears "funeral" feathers, and is close to dying in a natural world polluted by humans
- Clarke uses contrasts to show the sinister consequences of oil-spills:
 - The sand and sea are in "shadow" of darkness, but there is an unnatural "iridescence" in the brightly-coloured oil

Lines 7–9



**"For the ocean's lap with its mortal stain.
For Ahmed at the closed border.
For the soldier with his uniform of fire."**

Translation

- The poem continues its list of tributes, now describing coasts and borders
- The ocean leaves a "mortal stain" on the shoreline, which alludes to people who have died as a result of warfare, or at sea, and connotes to a "stain" of blood on the sand
- The next line names an individual who is unable to cross a border, and a soldier whose uniform is made of "fire", which connotes to weapons carried by the military

Clarke's intentions

- Clarke's poem considers the impact of war on nature and humans
- The reference to "Ahmed" indicates a specific area of the world, alluding to twentieth century Middle Eastern conflicts, specifically the Gulf War

Lines 10–12



**"For the gunsmith and the armourer,
the boy fusilier who joined for the company,
the farmer's sons, in it for the music."**

Translation

- The speaker lists a range of people who, perhaps unwittingly, contribute to war
- The list includes:
 - The people who make the weapons ("armourer" and "gunsmith")
 - The soldier who joined the army to make friends
 - The sons of farmers who are only doing it for sense of camaraderie ("music")

Clarke's intentions

- Clarke intends to show how war is successful because of the many people who support it, even when they do not even realise its effects
- Describing a "fusilier" as a boy, and referring to "farmer's sons" implies that they are naïve
- The reference to joining for the "company" and "music" alludes to war propaganda that encourages young boys to join the military to feel a sense of belonging

Lines 13–15



**"For the hook-beaked turtles,
the dugong and the dolphin,
the whale struck dumb by the missile's thunder."**

Translation

- A list of sea animals are included in the lament
- They have been silenced by a the noise ("thunder") of a missile

Clarke's intentions

- The **juxtaposition** of ideas about the natural world placed next to references to war creates a sinister effect, and presents Clarke's ideas about how war damages nature:
 - Imagery connecting a "missile" with "thunder" highlights the power of war
 - The list of sea animals, including lesser-known ones, accentuates the far reaching effects of war

Lines 16–18



“For the tern, the gull and the restless wader,
the long migrations and the slow dying,
the veiled sun and the stink of anger.”

Translation

- The speaker pays tribute to a range of sea birds (the “tern”, “gull” and “wader”)
- The speaker says that the birds are slowly dying because they have to fly further and further to migrate
- The speaker describes again the covering of the sun, as well as a metaphorical smell of “anger”, which may represent the speaker’s feelings, or the way nature feels

Clarke’s intentions

- The list of sea birds struggling to adapt to environmental change emphasises the extent of the damage done to the natural order of things
- Again, Clarke refers to darkness and connotes to a funeral in a “veiled” sun:
 - Dark imagery, such as a smell of “anger”, creates an ominous tone

Lines 19–21



“For the burnt earth and the sun put out,
the scalded ocean and the blazing well.
For vengeance, and the ashes of language.”

Translation

- The poem ends with descriptions of a world ravaged by war and bombs: the earth has been “burnt”, the ocean “scalded”, and wells of water are “blazing”
- Again, the speaker describes the sun becoming dark, but now it is entirely “put out”
- The final line suggests revenge is now the overriding concept for humanity, and that “language” has been burned into “ashes”, connoting to the end of civilisation and communication

Clarke’s intentions

- Clarke’s poem ends with a description of a dark landscape that has been scorched
- The “earth”, the “sun”, the “ocean”, and “language” have been destroyed
- The ending is not so much a warning as an **extended metaphor** of a funeral, during which the speaker grieves a world already dead



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme rewards skills of analysis, which they describe as “the ways in which writers achieve their effects”. Another way to think of the word “effects” is how a reader is encouraged to respond, or what questions have been raised. Poets create these “effects” through their choice of form, structure, or language.

To explore the poetry question, you could write about how Gillian Clarke, for example, uses the poem’s repetitive structure to represent a grieving speaker, or how the poem uses imagery throughout the poem that describes the effects of war.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered “writer’s methods” in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet’s choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet’s overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Clarke’s intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

The poem 'Lament' is formed as an elegy: a tribute to something, or someone, that has died. In this way, the speaker provides a sorrowful list of all the things they mourn, which highlights the deadly effects of war on the natural world, as well as on humans.



Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
The cost of war	The poem's free verse , with pauses at the end of lines, creates a slow and steady rhythm, but the speaker's tone of voice becomes passionate and angrier as the poem's polysyndeton lists increase, such as in "long migrations and the slow dying"	Clarke's speaker is a saddened and deeply respectful observer of the damage done to the natural world as a result of war, but there is also a sense of personal anger at the depth of destruction

Structure

Gillian Clarke's poem is a reflection on the vast and far-reaching effects of war on the natural world. The poem's speaker gravely and passionately lists all the damaging consequences.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	The poem is divided into 7 tercets, which gives the poem the effect of being a long, slow list	Clarke uses metonymy as she lists the many individual animals, birds, human beings, as well as the natural elements of sea, earth, and sun, that represent the extensive damage caused by war
	The poet uses anaphora in the repetition of "For" to begin stanzas	The poem is formed as a tribute to dying animals and the death of the natural world

Language

'Lament' describes a modern, war-torn world in a sinister extended metaphor that suggests a funeral. The poem implies the death of nature, and of civilisation, as a result of constant conflict.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	Metaphors connote to death: while the turtle lays eggs in a "sick" nest, and the birds have "funeral" feathers, the shorelines of the world are covered in a "mortal stain"	The poet uses the extended metaphor of a funeral to highlight the seriousness of the environmental crisis
The cost of war	Throughout the poem, natural imagery is placed alongside the language of war to present sinister connections, such as in "the whale struck dumb by the missile's thunder", but the poem's ending presents, not only a world on fire, but the "ashes" of language	Clarke explicitly suggests that the destruction caused by war will kill the natural world, but ambiguously refers to the death of language, which may refer to the idea of cultural identity or, perhaps, the death of what makes us human

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore the writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes that Gillian Clarke explores in 'Lament':

- Humans and nature
- The cost of war



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Something that examiners see a lot in poetry responses, and strongly warn against, are essays that begin with long introductions telling us about the poet's life and history. Instead, examiners reward essays that thoroughly explore the circumstances of the poet's ideas. To be rewarded highly for this, you could write about why Gillian Clarke may have wanted to raise questions about war and its impact on the environment in a twentieth century world.

Humans and nature

- Gillian Clarke, born in Wales in 1937, was the National Poet of Wales between 2008 and 2016
- Her poems often explore themes of nature, and the individual's relationship with their environment
- Clarke has said her work is inspired by Romantic poet, William Wordsworth
- In the poem, she mourns the destruction of the natural world, sharing the Romantic concern for nature:
 - The poem begins paying tribute to a struggling "green turtle" who cannot find a safe place to lay her eggs because their usual breeding-grounds are "sick"

- She refers to birds covered in oil, and “long migrations”
- These images highlight the damaging effects oil spills, such as the one in the Gulf in 1991, described as one of the worst oil spills in history
- The poem mentions endangered species to highlight how the spill devastated thousands of birds, fish, sea turtles, and marine mammals



The cost of war

- Gillian Clarke’s poetry often explores the consequences of poorly-reported news and corrupted media, especially in connection to how it affects the natural world
- The poem ‘Lament’ alludes, Clarke has said, to the 1990–1991 Gulf War:
 - It mentions a man called “Ahmed” at a “closed border” with an armed soldier
 - It details the burning of earth and “blazing” water wells
- The poem may also allude to a photograph taken in 1991 by Kenneth Jarecke:
 - In the photograph, not published by American media or press, a man is on fire in the Iraqi desert as armed vehicles drive by
 - Clarke’s poem describes young boys and “sons” joining the army to make friends, and ends with a description of the “ashes” of language
 - She alludes to war propaganda and, perhaps, the death of truth

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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‘The Cockroach’

Here is a detailed guide to Kevin Halligan’s poem ‘The Cockroach’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods:** an exploration of Halligan’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Halligan’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Kevin Halligan’s intention and message

‘The Cockroach’ overview

The poem, ‘The Cockroach’, by Kevin Halligan, is a [sonnet](#) that explores the human condition through the [allegory](#) of a wandering cockroach. The cockroach is satisfied in his path at first, but then becomes restless and, finally, unsure about what to do next. The poet uses the cockroach to explore the difficulty of finding our purpose in life.

‘The Cockroach’ breakdown

Lines 1–2



“I watched a giant cockroach start to pace,
Skirting a ball of dust that rode the floor.”

Translation

- A speaker observes a cockroach crossing the floor and avoiding a “ball of dust” by going around it (“Skirting”)

Halligan’s intentions

- Halligan introduces a [first person](#) speaker who observes the movements of a cockroach, noticing how it manages to navigate around obstacles in its way

Lines 3–4



“At first he seemed quite satisfied to trace
A path between the wainscot and the door,”

Translation

- The speaker says the cockroach was happy enough going back and forth on one path, a line that went along the wooden panelled walls (“wainscot”) to the door

Halligan’s intentions

- The cockroach, which represents human beings, is “satisfied” with a routine, but Halligan implies this will end with the phrase “At first”, perhaps alluding to greed

Lines 5–9



“But soon he turned to jog in crooked rings,
Circling the rusty table leg and back,
And flipping right over to scratch his wings –
As if the victim of a mild attack
Of restlessness that worsened over time.”

Translation

- The speaker watches the cockroach suddenly change course and move in “crooked” circles, go around the “table leg”, and turn onto its back to “scratch”
- The speaker compares the cockroach to someone having an “attack”:
 - The “restlessness”, although only “mild” at first, becomes worse as his movements become wilder and more erratic

Halligan’s intentions

- As Halligan describes the cockroach having an “attack” of boredom, he compares it to a “victim”, which implies it is subject to inner turmoil and impulsive behaviour
- Halligan uses the cockroach to show aspects of human behaviour, and implies life is not always smooth

Lines 10–11



“After a while, he climbed an open shelf
And stopped. He looked uncertain where to go.”

Translation

- The cockroach climbs up a shelf, but then he stops, confused about where to go next

Halligan’s intentions

- Halligan’s cockroach, once it has scaled the heights of a shelf, seems to have reached some sort of peak, and becomes without purpose and clarity
- This may allude to the idea that individuals work towards a goal, only to become aimless and doubtful when they have achieved it

Lines 12–13



“Was this due payment for some vicious crime
A former life had led to? I don’t know,”

Translation

- The speaker watches the cockroach and wonders if the uncertainty it feels is punishment for doing something bad in a “former life”, but they are unsure

Halligan’s intentions

- As the speaker’s voice becomes clear, and they ask a question about morality, the poem’s philosophical nature comes to the fore:
 - The speaker’s uncertainty is similar to that of the cockroach
- The lines, and the poem as a whole, raises questions about human struggles:
 - The speaker asks if such doubt is fair justice for evil acts the cockroach (and humans) may have committed before reaching their successful position
 - Perhaps Halligan asks if greed can lead to dissatisfaction

Line 14



“Except I thought I recognised myself.”

Translation

- The speaker concludes their observation of the cockroach by saying the one thing they are sure of is that they recognise aspects of themselves in the cockroach

Halligan’s intentions

- Halligan’s poem ends with an unlikely comparison between humans and a cockroach
- Halligan suggests humans are as vulnerable as the insect to the problems in life
- Halligan reflects on the individual’s path to find meaning



Examiner Tips and Tricks

A good start to writing a “personal and evaluative engagement” is to engage with the key words of the question and think carefully about your introduction. Your introduction (or thesis statement) should set up a personal response that focuses on the writer's ideas, and engages with the specific question asked. Avoid listing all the techniques in the poem, or giving biographical and historical information that is not connected to your points.



Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered “writer's methods” in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

Examiners require you to **focus** on the **poem's deeper ideas**, and in a sensitive way. So, discuss how the **poet's methods** reveal their **ideas or themes**. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Kevin Halligan's intentions in terms of his choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Kevin Halligan's poem, 'The Cockroach', is delivered by a philosophical speaker. It is formed as a sonnet, perhaps to create a sense of order, but Halligan deviates from traditional rules to present disruption and confusion.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	Traditionally, a sonnet is divided into sections of eight and six lines, but Halligan's poem has its volta at line 12, at which point a first person speaker asks themselves a question to which they do not know the answer	Halligan's poem is formed as a long observation of a cockroach that is concluded by a reflective, yet resigned speaker who sees a similar lack of meaning in their life

Structure

Halligan deviates from traditional sonnet structures to present a strange observation of a cockroach crossing the floor. At first, the cockroach is steady and calm, but changes suddenly to a state of restless confusion, which mimics the speaker's own sense of uncertainty.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem is in iambic pentameter with a regular rhyme scheme to create a regular, conversational voice, but rhyming lines ABAB CDCD change to EFG EGF creating a destabilised speaker	As the cockroach's journey becomes more disorderly, Halligan's speaker changes from calm to anxious to reflect their similarly growing tension and uncertainty
	This is further emphasised by caesura in “And stopped. He looked uncertain where to go.”	

Language

Kevin Halligan's poem 'The Cockroach' is an allegory as it uses a cockroach to symbolise humans. The poem's setting contributes to the idea that both the cockroach and the speaker are struggling in a difficult set of circumstances.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	Imagery connoting to neglect describes the speaker and cockroach's environment, such as “a ball of dust” and a “rusty” table leg	Halligan shows the insect and the speaker in the same environment which strengthens the idea that they have similar experiences and struggles
Individual identity	Verbs are used to describe the cockroach's changing state of mind: “pace” and “trace” become “jog”, “Circling”, and “flipping”, which ends with “climbed” and “stopped”	Halligan considers an individual's life journey through a cockroach that grows increasingly more erratic and confused as it tries to find a sense of purpose

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore the writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes that Kevin Halligan explores in 'The Cockroach':

- Individual identity
- Humans and nature



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Sometimes a writer's choice of structure and form overlap in terms of the effect or meaning they create. In your response to the poetry question, it is best to start your paragraphs with a point of analysis (an interpretation or argument statement), such as "Halligan disrupts the traditional form of a sonnet to create a sense of disorder." Then, support this statement with a close exploration of how aspects of form and/or structure and/or language reveal the speaker's attitudes.



Your notes

Individual identity

- Kevin Halligan is a Canadian poet born in 1964
- The poem was published in 1999 and later appeared in his 2009 collection called *Utopia*, when Halligan was living in an unstable Cambodia:
 - The title of the collection raises ideas about a perfect world and morality
 - In 'The Cockroach', Halligan considered aimless "restlessness"
- The poem shows influences of other works that use a symbolic cockroach to consider human transformation, resilience, and vulnerabilities:
 - These include Franz Kafka's *Metamorphosis* and Don Marquis' *archy and mehitabel*, which can be considered critical comparisons
- More recently, British novelist Ian McEwan's 2019 novel, *Cockroach*, uses the symbolism of cockroaches to defame individuals, or show humans as base:
 - Halligan's poem asks if the cockroach's doubt is punishment for evil acts

Humans and nature

- Halligan's sonnet, 'The Cockroach', pays tribute to traditional and classical poetry
- The subject matter, an individual trying to understand their inner turmoil by watching nature, may show Romantic influences:
 - The final line ends on a very personal, bleak conclusion, often found in Romantic poems: "I thought I recognised myself"
- Halligan's simple language resonates with Romantic poetry's aims to show the deepest expressions of the human experience with simple imagery:
 - In 'The Cockroach', Halligan describes a simple floor, with a "ball of dust"

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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'Follower'

Here is a detailed guide to Seamus Heaney's poem 'Follower', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line "translation" of the poem's meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods:** an exploration of Heaney's poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Heaney's poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Seamus Heaney's intention and message

'Follower' overview

Seamus Heaney's poem, 'Follower', is a reflection on a child and parent's changing relationship. It explores how the power dynamics between a father and son shifts as their roles naturally reverse over time.

'Follower' breakdown

Lines 1–3



"My father worked with a horse–plough,
His shoulders globed like a full sail strung
Between the shafts and the furrow."

Translation

- A child speaker describes their father as a strong farmer with shoulders as wide and broad as a sail:
 - They seemed to take up the whole width of the ditch he is ploughing

Heaney's intentions

- Heaney's [first person](#) speaker describes the way they remember their father
- [Imagery](#) connotes to the father's strength and natural ability to harness the elements, implying the child's sense of awe for their father's size and power

Lines 4–7



"The horses strained at his clicking tongue.

An expert. He would set the wing
And fit the bright steel–pointed sock.
The sod rolled over without breaking,"

Translation

- The speaker describes their father managing a horse easily: he is an "expert"
- The father is able to complete his farming tasks competently

Heaney's intentions

- By starting a new [stanza](#) with the short phrase and [caesura](#), Heaney draws attention to the father's mastery (or expertise)
- Heaney's speaker remembers their father clearly and in detail, which highlights the influence he had on his son as a child watching him go about his daily work

Lines 8–12



"At the headrig, with a single pluck

Of reins, the sweating team turned round
And back into the land. His eye
Narrowed and angled at the ground,
Mapping the furrow exactly."



Translation

- The speaker's memory of their father is vivid: each movement or gesture is detailed:
 - The father easily directs the horses with a "single pluck" of the "reins"
 - Both the father and horse have been working hard and are "sweating"
 - He carefully plans where to dig the "furrow" or trench

Heaney's intentions

- Heaney illustrates the power of memory as his speaker remembers his father in present tense verbs, as if he is there watching his father "mapping" and "sweating"
- Again, the speaker remembers how exacting and careful his father is, which implies a sense of pride in his work

Lines 13–16



"I stumbled in his hob-nailed wake,
Fell sometimes on the polished sod;
Sometimes he rode me on his back
Dipping and rising to his plod."

Translation

- The speaker remembers themselves as a child, and how they struggled to keep up with their father, especially the tracks of his father's boots (his "hob-nailed wake")
- When the child fell, the father would put the child on his shoulders and he would bounce to the "dipping and rising" of his footsteps ("plod")

Heaney's intentions

- The poem's tender memory of a child trying to keep up with their father conveys a sense of nostalgia
- Heaney uses the symbolic ideas of a child in his father's large footsteps to suggest the speaker is intimidated by their father's "polished" work and large stature:
 - Heaney begins to introduce imbalances in relationships between child and parent and, specifically, a son under his father's critical eye

Lines 17–20



"I wanted to grow up and plough,
To close one eye, stiffen my arm.
All I ever did was follow
In his broad shadow round the farm."

Translation

- The voice of an adult speaker reflects on their feelings as a child
- The child wanted to become a good farmer and emulate their father, but they only ever followed in his large "shadow", implying the son was unable to be like his father

Heaney's intentions

- Heaney illustrates, through the speaker's reflection, how traditional expectations of sons becoming their fathers may cause tension in family relationships
- Heaney also raises the question of traditional masculine roles with characteristics such as physical strength and stoic discipline

Lines 21–24



"I was a nuisance, tripping, falling,
Yapping always. But today
It is my father who keeps stumbling
Behind me, and will not go away."



Translation

- The speaker accepts that their youthful enthusiasm and limited physical abilities must have been a "nuisance", or an annoyance, to their father
- However, the poem ends with a sudden shift in perspective as the speaker returns to present day ("was" becomes "is"):
 - The son is now an adult and their father has grown weak and dependent, just like they were when they were little

Heaney's intentions

- Heaney's speaker reflects on how changing power imbalances between father and son happen naturally over time
- Heaney's poem concludes with a suddenly impatient speaker
- There is a sense of **irony** as the child is now stronger and more able than their father:
 - Present tense verbs, "tripping", "falling" and "yapping", describe the child's weaknesses, but now the father is "stumbling" and following his son around



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme, analysis is rewarded when your answer gives a close exploration of how aspects of form and/or structure and/or language reveal the speaker's attitudes. For instance, in Seamus Heaney's poem 'Follower', the poet uses a childhood memory to illustrate tensions between fathers and sons.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Seamus Heaney's intentions in terms of his choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Seamus Heaney's speaker reflects on their childhood in a **ballad**. The regular and steady form reflects the father's sense of order and efficiency.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Family love	The poem is divided into six regular quatrains with regular line lengths	Heaney's disciplined form helps to convey the memory of the speaker's reliable and exacting father and, perhaps, the idea of rigid fatherly expectations

Structure

Heaney's speaker is reflective as he remembers his childhood but, at times, the voice is broken to reveal tensions between the father and son.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem's iambic tetrameter, with pauses at the end of most lines, creates a bouncing and steady rhythm, but this is broken with caesura and enjambment when the speaker's tension rises, such as in "Yapping always. But today"	Heaney delivers ideas about the complexities of growing up: the child speaker simultaneously admires and feels intimidated by their father and, by the end, is ironically annoyed by his dependence

Language

Seamus Heaney's poem describes the vivid memory of a child as they watch their father work. The poem portrays the strong influence of parent and child relationships, and the depth of their connection.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Family love	The poem brings to life a childhood memory of a boy and his father on their farm, using present tense verbs, like "sweating" and "falling", alongside imagery, such as the simile comparing his father's shoulders with "a full sail", or the mark of his boots in the "furrows" of "polished sod"	Heaney uses vivid and immersive descriptions to present the impact of a father on his young son

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore** the **writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes that Seamus Heaney examines in his poem 'Follower':

- Individual identity
- Family Love



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward an answer that responds "sensitively and in considerable detail" to the way the writer achieves their effects. You are being asked to explore the poem beyond surface meanings to show deeper awareness of ideas and attitudes. While knowing about a poet's background will help you understand the themes they examine, your poetry answer should only mention the poet's biographical information if it supports a point of analysis.

Individual identity

- Seamus Heaney was born in rural Ireland in 1939:
 - In 1995, he won the Nobel Prize in Literature
- His poetry often reflects Irish literary and agricultural traditions
- Seamus Heaney's poem 'Follower' is part of a 1966 anthology "Death of a Naturalist"
- Heaney's life as a farmer's son is reflected in the poem through its description of a father ploughing a field and "mapping" furrows:
 - The speaker says, "I wanted to grow up and plough", which contributes to the poem's autobiographical and reflective nature

Family love

- Seamus Heaney's poetry often raises themes of family relationships and childhood
- The poem 'Follower' explores the relationship between a father and son
- Traditional values within family relationships, specifically between father and son, are depicted through a memory
- The son expresses admiration for their father's traditionally masculine qualities, such as his physical strength and his pride in exacting agricultural work
- But the adult speaker also reflects on childhood insecurities: "All I ever did was follow/In his broad shadow round the farm" and stumble "in his hob-nailed wake"
- The poem's conclusion considers the naturally occurring shift in the balance of power between a father and son
- As physical characteristics change over time, roles reverse:
 - When the father grows old, it is he who is weak and dependant on his son

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

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Songs of Ourselves: Volume 1: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Poetry in English. Cambridge University Press & Assessment, 2018.

‘Storyteller’

Here is a detailed guide to Liz Lochhead’s poem ‘Storyteller’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods:** an exploration of Lochhead’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Lochhead’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Liz Lochhead’s intention and message

‘Storyteller’ overview

The poem ‘Storyteller’, written by Liz Lochhead, describes a storyteller who is central to a community of peasant women. The poem celebrates the way listening to stories offers escape from the women’s work, and explores the social importance of stories and tales.

‘Storyteller’ breakdown

Lines 1–5



“she sat down
at the scoured table
in the swept kitchen
beside the dresser with its cracked delft.
And every last crumb of daylight was salted away.”

Translation

- The **omniscient** narrator introduces a woman (“she”) in a simple kitchen:
 - There are some “cracked delft” (Dutch plates) on the “dresser”
- She has finished all her domestic chores:
 - The table has been scrubbed, the floor swept, and it is dark (“daylight” has been “salted away”)

Lochhead’s intentions

- Lochhead begins an immersive description of a woman at the end of a day of domestic chores:
 - Lochhead uses **metaphor** “crumbs of daylight” and “salted away” to convey the idea that the woman’s life revolves around domestic activities
- The setting is a simple, yet well cleaned kitchen, introducing themes of domestic labour, as well as pride in one’s environment

Lines 6–11



“No one could say the stories were useless
for as the tongue clacked
five or forty fingers stitched
corn was grated from the husk
patchwork was pieced
or the darning done.”

Translation

- The speaker goes on to say that everyone agrees the stories have a purpose
- The woman tells long stories (her tongue “clacked”), while other women prepare food (grate “corn”) or sew (“stitched” and “darning”)

Lochhead’s intentions

- The **enjambment** and **alliteration** in these lines, such as “patchwork was pieced”, reflects long, passionate stories that help the women through dull work
- Lochhead highlights the power of storytelling, and the sense of community between the women despite their many chores:
 - The tasks are combined with listening to the tales, implying the stories are just as important as the work



Lines 12–14



**“Never the one to slander her shiftless.
Daily sloven or spotless no matter whether
dishwater or tasty was her soup.”**

Translation

- The speaker refers to how the storyteller told her stories while others worked, so she was “shiftless”
- They did not mind, though, so they would not “slander” or speak ill of her
- They liked the storyteller, whether untidy (“sloven”), and if the soup was “tasty” or like “dishwater”

Lochhead’s intentions

- Lochhead emulates the excitement of the stories by portraying how all other matters were ignored, which shows a close community
- The strange and ambiguous combination of words may reflect the way the storyteller crafts her stories

Lines 15–18



**“To tell the stories was her work.
It was like spinning,
gathering thin air to the singlest strongest
thread. Night in”**

Translation

- The speaker says that telling stories was the woman’s job
- When she tells stories it is as if she is spinning cotton (“thread”)

Lochhead’s intentions

- The present tense verbs “spinning” and “gathering” creates a sense of immediacy, which helps to convey the excitement of the storytelling
- The **simile**, “like spinning”, connotes to the suspenseful stories the storyteller tells:
 - The metaphor ‘spinning a yarn’ is a nineteenth century sailors’ expression
 - It is thought to describe the custom of telling stories during dull work such as yarn-twisting or thread weaving
- The metaphor “gathering air” may allude to the storyteller pausing for breath

Lines 19–20



**“she’d have us waiting, held
breath, for the ending we knew by heart.”**

Translation

- The speaker adds that each night they would meet to hear the rest of the story, even though they often knew exactly how it would end

Lochhead’s intentions

- Lochhead emphasises the intrigue of the stories, and how the storyteller builds anticipation that lasts all day, which is a welcome relief from the boring routine
- The power of stories is conveyed in the emotive “we knew by heart”, alluding to how well loved they were, like fairytales

Lines 21–25





"And at first light
as the women stirred themselves to build the fire
as the peasant's feet felt for clogs
as thin grey washed over flat fields
the stories dissolved in the whorl of the ear"

 Your notes

Translation

- The speaker explains that the stories were told at night and then, in the morning, the women finally moved to make a fire and find their shoes ("clogs")
- The speaker describes the "grey" sky and "flat fields" outside the home
- The night's stories run around in their heads ("in the whorl of the ear")

Lochhead's intentions

- Lochhead describes a cosy domestic scene with a "fire" and the alliterative "feet felt"
- This is contrasted with the landscape outdoors, which is "thin grey" and "flat"
- Despite the dullness and routine of their lives, the stories bring excitement

Lines 26–30



"but they
hung themselves upside down
in the sleeping heads of the children
till they flew again
in the storytellers night."

Translation

- The speaker compares the stories with bats who sleep "upside down" during the day
- The stories are in the children's minds, and they will be spoken of again at nighttime

Lochhead's intentions

- Lochhead's poem ends with a metaphor that brings a sense of mystery to the stories:
 - The final line alludes to stories as bats flying at night, presenting stories as mysterious and exciting, but that disappear to a degree during the day
- Reference to "sleeping children" may allude to the stories being passed down, and the importance of the oral tradition



Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes. Specifically, examiners reward answers that consider the "deeper meanings of the poem". This means you should spend time thinking about, for example, the reason Liz Lochhead creates a simple setting in which to present the excitement of storytelling.

Writer's methods

This section is organised into: form, structure, and language. All three are valuable "writer's methods" to explore when you answer the poetry question in the CIE Literature for English exam. You should consider the poet's choice of form (its shape and the perspective of the speaker), its structure (the speaker's tone of voice), and the language used to create effect and meaning.

Examiners require you to focus on the poem's deeper ideas, and in a sensitive way. So, discuss how the poet's methods reveal their ideas or themes. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Liz Lochhead's intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Liz Lochhead creates a long, immersive, free flowing form to portray the significance of stories to peasant women in a small community.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
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Cultural identity	The poem's four stanzas increase in length as the poem progresses: this mimics the women's emotions as events of the evening unfold (before the stories, during the stories, and afterwards)	Lochhead's poem reflects the women's anticipation of the nightly stories, and the way storytelling brings the community together
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Structure

Lochhead's **free verse** poem reflects the long and passionate stories the peasant woman tells, and conveys how her stories bring excitement and relief from the routine of daily work.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem's lack of rhyme scheme , along with fluid lines, mimics the lengthy nature of the woman's storytelling, but anaphora in line 22–24 contrast the free-flowing rhythm to reflect the dullness of the women's daily lives	Lochhead illustrates how the women complete the same daily tasks in the same kitchen day after day, but she suggests that stories relieve this boredom and, thus, she raises the profile of traditional storytelling

Language

Liz Lochhead's poem creates a vivid image of how the dull lives and mundane chores of modest and marginalised women are enriched and motivated by stories told around a kitchen table.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	While the poem begins with the immersive "she sat down" and a description of a simple kitchen with "cracked" plates and a "scoured" table to portray a simple life, the stories told in the kitchen are presented as exciting with onomatopoeia , like in "clacked" and "husk", as well as rich metaphor alluding to spinning wheels and bats	Lochhead shows how stories become part of the rich tradition of a small peasant community of domestic women

Understanding the text

The poetry questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an **informed, personal response**, which means that it is not enough just to know the poem, but that you will also need to develop a **sound understanding** of the poem's **themes, main ideas, settings, situations** and **events** to explore the writer's intentions and methods. This section has been divided into two main themes that Liz Lochhead examines in her poem 'Storyteller':

- Individual identity
- Cultural identity



Examiner Tips and Tricks

A good start to writing a "personal and evaluative engagement" is to engage with the key words of the question and think carefully about your introduction. Examiners suggest that you set up a clear argument that focuses on the writer's purposes or aims. Think about why the poet raises certain themes, or what ideas are challenged in their poem. This might be because of their background or the society they lived in. This is how you can connect 'context' to your argument.

Individual identity

- Liz Lochhead is a Scottish poet, born in 1947
- Her work is inspired by American feminist writers who rework old myths, as well as Scottish oral culture and European myths
- The poem 'Storyteller' is the introduction to a series of poems called The Grimm Sisters, written in 1981:
 - The collection reworks old fairy-tales and myths with a feminist perspective, particularly those written by the Brothers Grimm
- Lochhead's work re-enchants or subverts everyday reality with mythic and fairytale elements:
 - In her poem 'Storyteller', the lives of domestic women are enriched by magical stories that dissolve in the "into the whorl of the ear"
 - In 'Storyteller' Lochhead presents a female orator who is able to capture the attention of a community all night because of her masterful narratives
- Some of the references in the poem suggest the setting is Dutch:
 - For example, there are "flat fields", the women wear "clogs", and the plates are "cracked delft"
 - Arguably, the poem represents the daily chores of any domestic woman
 - They sit around a "scoured table" and a "swept" floor

Cultural identity

- Twentieth century literature saw a revival of the oral tradition of storytelling, and often celebrates the power of performance poetry:



Your notes

- Liz Lochhead's poetry uses alliteration and onomatopoeic words to elevate the sound of the language
- For example, in the lines, "the tongue clacked/five or forty fingers" or in "darning was done" and "peasant's feet felt for clogs"
- Lochhead's poem 'Storyteller' raises the idea of cultural continuity through storytelling:
 - The celebrates the way a woman captivates her community with her suspenseful storytelling around a kitchen table
 - For instance, in the line, "she'd have us waiting, held/breath"
 - Metaphor alluding to "spinning" wheels and "sleeping heads of children" refers to the way fairytales are passed down "by heart" and continually loved

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

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Songs of Ourselves: Volume 1: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Poetry in English. Cambridge University Press & Assessment, 2018.

‘Before the Sun’

Here is a detailed guide to Charles Mungoshi's poem 'Before the Sun', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line "translation" of the poem's meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods:** an exploration of Mungoshi's poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Mungoshi's poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Charles Mungoshi's intention and message

‘Before the Sun’ overview

Charles Mungoshi's poem 'Before the Sun', celebrates the simple joys of manual labour in a rural environment. Through a depiction of a young boy cutting wood, Mungoshi portrays a close relationship and sense of harmony between humans and nature.

‘Before the Sun’ breakdown

Lines 1–4



"Intense blue morning
promising early heat
and later in the afternoon,
heavy rain."

Translation

- The [omniscient narrator](#) describes a sunny morning that begins with an "intense" heat and turns into a tropical rainstorm later in the day

Mungoshi's intentions

- The poem opens by focusing on extreme weather, creating a rich sensory mood, and showing the power of nature
- The speaker shows awareness of the natural world, knowing that heat and water are what crops (and people) need to develop and survive

Lines 5–11



"The bright chips
fly from the sharp axe
for some distance through the air,
arc,
and eternities later,
settle down in showers
on the dewy grass."

Translation

- The poet describes how wood "chips" scatter and form an "arc" in the air as they are chopped with the "axe"
- They take a long time to land ("eternities"), and then they drop on wet "grass"

Mungoshi's intentions

- Mungoshi describes wood chips scattering like rain, a [metaphor](#) that connects the wood-cutter boy with his environment: he creates rain-like woodchips
- The speaker's youth is conveyed through the use of "eternities" as, for young people, time can seem longer

Lines 12–15





"It is a big log:
but when you are fourteen
big logs
are what you want."

Translation

- The narrator says that the teenage boy is happy to have a large piece of wood as this will allow him to prove himself

Mungoshi's intentions

- Mungoshi raises the theme of growing up by depicting a teenage boy carrying out physically demanding manual labour, and taking pride in the challenge

Lines 16–19



"The wood gives off
a sweet nose-cleansing odour
which (unlike sawdust)
doesn't make one sneeze."

Translation

- The narrator describes the smell of the wood: it is a pure smell, unlike "sawdust"

Mungoshi's intentions

- The poet contrasts the natural wood the boy cuts with the man-made, toxic release of sawdust

Lines 20–25



"It sends up a thin spiral
of smoke which later straightens
and flutes out
to the distant sky: a signal
of some sort,
or a sacrificial prayer."

Translation

- The poet describes the smoke that rises from the fire the boy has made with the wood he has cut: it creates a "spiral" that becomes tube-shaped ("flutes")
- It looks like a smoke signal, or as if someone has performed a "sacrificial" ritual

Mungoshi's intentions

- Mungoshi once again links the boy's labour to the natural environment
- The smoke in the "distant sky" is connected to spiritual communication which suggests the boy respects and worships nature

Lines 26–27



"The wood hisses,
The sparks fly."

Translation

- The narrator describes the fire the boy has made, it is loud and fierce ("sparks fly")

Mungoshi's intentions

- Mungoshi's descriptions are sensory, focusing on sounds, smells, and the air:
 - The fire is described as if it is alive: it "hisses" and "sparks"
 - Mungoshi presents nature as a living thing

Lines 28–33



"And when the sun
finally shows up
in the East like some
latecomer to a feast
I have got two cobs of maize
ready for it."

Translation

- Now it is dawn: the sun rises, and because it has missed all the events of the night, it is like a "latecomer" to a "feast" or party
- A **first person** voice is introduced: the boy says he has corn ready to give the sun

Mungoshi's intentions

- Using **personification** to make the sun seem like a guest to his "feast", Mungoshi shows a close connection between the boy and nature
- Finally, the speaker's voice is heard, giving the poem a personal, intimate quality

Lines 34–37



"I tell the sun to come share
with me the roasted maize
and the sun just winks
like a grown-up."

Translation

- The speaker asks the sun to join him in eating the corn he has cooked
- But the sun does not answer, it just "winks"; perhaps it glints in the sky
- The speaker says the sun is like an adult, saying little

Mungoshi's intentions

- There is a light-hearted quality to Mungoshi's poem to show the innocence and optimism of the young boy
- Mungoshi conveys how close humans are to nature when they are in solitude:
 - Mungoshi evokes themes of spirituality in his depiction of a boy thanking nature (the rising sun) by offering his corn
- Mungoshi's young speaker presents ideas about growing up as he likens the sun to an adult

Lines 38–46



"So I go ahead, taking big
alternate bites:
one for the sun,
one for me.
This one for the sun,
this one for me:
till the cobs
are just two little skeletons
in the sun."

Translation

- The speaker describes how he shares his corn with the sun, pretending the sun takes a bite of his corn (although it is really him eating it)
- When all the corn has been chewed off the cobs, they are like "skeletons"

Mungoshi's intentions

- The joy and harmony between humans and nature is illustrated by the tender image of a boy pretending the sun is an imaginary friend
- The striking image of the devoured cobs of corn as "little skeletons in the sun" helps Mungoshi convey the boy's innocence:

- Although as a final line, it leaves a sinister image in the reader's mind, perhaps foreshadowing struggles ahead for the boy and for nature



Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes. Specifically, examiners reward answers that consider the "deeper meanings of the poem". This means you should spend time thinking about, for example, the reason Charles Mungoshi creates an intensely sensual setting in order to examine the relationship between humans and nature.



Writer's methods

This section is organised into: form, structure, and language. The poetry question in the CIE Literature for English exam wants you to consider all three as "writer's methods" that create meaning or convey ideas. So, your answer should consider the poet's choice of form (its shape and the perspective of the speaker), its structure (the rhythm, rhyme, and tone of voice), and language (imagery) that create effect and meaning.

Examiners require you to **focus** on the **poem's deeper ideas**, and in a sensitive way. To do this you can discuss how the poet's methods reveal their aim or purpose. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Charles Mungoshi's intentions in terms of his choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Charles Mungoshi's poem 'Before the Sun' is in an irregular and free flowing form which portrays the spontaneous reflections of a young boy carrying out his daily tasks and feelings, at one with his environment.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	The poem's nine stanzas vary in length: some stanzas are lengthy descriptions, and others are like haikus (such as in "The wood hisses,/The sparks fly") to convey a simple yet profound experience	Mungoshi conveys the calm solitude of a boy in his natural environment through a first person intimate and rambling voice

Structure

Mungoshi's poem is conversational, with no rhyme scheme or regular rhythm. This contributes to the spontaneous, relaxed voice of an innocent speaker who is excited about growing up.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem's lack of rhyme, along with fluid, rambling lines, convey the young boy's thoughts as he reflects on the natural elements, his personal challenges, "prayer", and talks to the sun	Mungoshi portrays a teenage boy's innocence and exuberance as he spends time alone cutting wood all night and into a new day

Language

In 'Before the Sun', Mungoshi uses sensory imagery to present the significance of simple moments of solitude in nature.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	The poem describes an extreme and vibrant landscape with words like "Intense", "bright" and "heavy", and simple sensory imagery that brings to life the "sweet" wood that "hisses", the "dewy grass" and "roasted maize"	Mungoshi portrays a hot and sunny rural landscape that is rich in smell and texture to emphasise the depth of the experience

Understanding the text

The poetry questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an **informed, personal response**, which means that it is not enough just to know the poem, but that you will also need to develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events** to explore the writer's intentions and methods. This section has been divided into two main themes that Charles Mungoshi examines in his poem 'Before the Sun':

- Individual identity
- Humans and nature



Examiner Tips and Tricks

One of the best ways to write a “personal and evaluative engagement” is to spend some time thinking about the question. You could call this planning time. Examiners are looking for an introduction that presents your own personal interpretation of the poem in the question, so you will need some time to think about this.

So, instead of setting straight to writing an introduction that lists all the techniques you are about to analyse, or one that begins with the poet’s biography, carefully consider how you would answer the specific question you have been asked, and write this in your introduction.



Individual identity

- Charles Mungoshi was born in Zimbabwe in 1947 and grew up on a farm
- He worked for the Forestry Commission before he began writing:
 - The poem ‘Before the Sun’ is semi-autobiographical in nature
 - It depicts a young boy cutting wood with familiarity and expertise, in a hot, rural landscape
- Mungoshi’s poetry often covers themes about identity and masculinity:
 - The poem ‘Before the Sun’ describes a teenage boy who is keen to prove his strength as he wants to cut “big” logs
 - At the same time, the teenage boy is innocent, playing games with the sun and describing it as a “grown-up”

Humans and nature

- Having grown up in Zimbabwe, Charles Mungoshi writes about the familiar landscape of Southern Africa
- In ‘Before the Sun’, Mungoshi describes the heat of the day to come, the “intense blue” and “heavy” rain, alluding to the close connection between the weather and those living in sub-tropical region
- The boy eats “maize” and shares it with the sun, conveying his deep respect and close connection with nature:
 - He refers to “prayer” and “sacrificial” rituals, suggesting worship of the sun
- The final line, describing two “skeletons” in the sun, may warn against a threat to nature, which presents a traditional, simple life alongside a twentieth century concern
- Mungoshi’s poem uses a style similar to a Japanese poetic style in its short, simple descriptions, such as in “bright chips” and “sharp axe”, and occasional haiku:
 - This allows him to show the starkness and simplicity of nature, as well as its power to create a deep experience

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

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‘A Married State’

Here is a detailed guide to Katherine Philips’ poem ‘A Married State’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods:** an exploration of Philips’ poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Philips’ poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Katherine Philips’ intention and message

‘A Married State’ overview

Katherine Philips expresses a bold opinion on the state of marriage from a female perspective in seventeenth century Britain. Her poem, ‘A Married State’, offers advice to all single women on why they should avoid marriage as it often limits rather than frees women.

‘A Married State’ breakdown

Lines 1–2



“A married state affords but little ease;
The best of husbands are so hard to please.”

Translation

- The poem begins with an **omniscient narrator** declaring that marriage brings little comfort (“ease”), and that it is difficult to keep even the “best” husbands happy

Philips’ intentions

- The poem’s opening statement offers a harsh criticism on the trials of marriage
- Philips extends this criticism to all marriages, even the “best ones”, and claims it is because husbands cannot be easily satisfied

Lines 3–4



“This in wives’ careful faces you may spell,
Though they dissemble their misfortunes well.”

Translation

- The poet says that you can see the ill-ease in the wives’ faces:
 - They are “careful” to hide their troubles and “misfortunes”
 - They “dissemble” their faces, meaning they put on a happy face as a disguise

Philips’ intentions

- Philips hints at the imbalance of power in seventeenth century marriages, and how this leads to deceit
- She alludes to females being forced into marriage, implying wives cannot express their negative feelings which, in turn, represses them:
 - If only people would look more closely, they would see that the wives are pretending

Lines 5–6



"A virgin state is crowned with much content,
It's always happy as it's innocent:"



Translation

- The narrator says that virginity is a happy ("content") state to be in as it is innocent

Philips' intentions

- Philips' reference to a crown suggests that, for women, staying single brings power and contentment
- By describing virginity as innocent, Philips implies marriage is the opposite:
 - Perhaps that the state, or experience, of marriage is corrupt

Lines 7–10



"No blustering husbands to create your fears,
No pangs of childbirth to extort your tears,
No children's cries for to offend your ears,
Few worldly crosses to distract your prayers."

Translation

- The narrator offers a list of reasons to stay single and childless:
 - There is less fear as there are no "blustering", bad-tempered husbands
 - There is no pain from childbirth, nor constantly crying children
 - The image of "worldly crosses" may refer to temptations that would take one away from spirituality or religion ("prayers")

Philips' intentions

- The poet's argument on the merits of staying single is made more persuasive with **anaphora**, "No"
- Philips' list of "tears" and "fears", offences, and distractions avoided by staying single uses emotive and religious **imagery** to strengthen her argument:
 - The suggestion is that the speaker has found out these things too late

Lines 11–12



"Thus are you freed from all the cares that do
Attend on matrimony, and a husband too."

Translation

- The poet says that staying single and childless means "you" (women) are free of all the worries that go along with marriage ("matrimony") and motherhood

Philips' intentions

- The confident voice of Philips' narrator presents a female speaker who uses logic and persuasive language to present a strong argument against marriage
- The poem subverts traditional and patriarchal ideas of marriage by suggesting a husband is an annoyance, or a burden, rather than a benefit

Lines 13–16



"Therefore, Madam, be advised by me:
Turn, turn apostate to love's levity.
Suppress wild nature if she dare rebel,
There's no such thing as leading apes in hell."

Translation

- The narrator addresses a female listener ("madam"), and offers advice:
 - "Turn" away and renounce the shallowness ("levity") of love

- Do not allow temptation, desire, or a "wild nature" to take control
- The poet references an old proverb about unmarried women, and says it is not true:
 - The proverb stated that unmarried women caused otherwise good men to stray from their marriages, like "apes in hell"

Philips' intentions

- Philips' poem is presented as advice to all unmarried women
- The strength of her tone is conveyed in the repetition of "turn", and emphasised in the word "apostate", which means to desert or abandon a cause
- Philips alludes to the idea of self control as necessary to avoid marriage
- She calls for abstinence and self-discipline, ending with a witty and defiant reference to traditional criticisms of single women



Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes and, specifically, the "deeper meanings of the poem". Examiners advise you to spend more time thinking about, for example, the reason **why** Katherine Philips creates a calm and reasoned argument, rather than a free-flowing and emotional speaker.

To achieve a convincing analysis, mentioning rhythm and rhyme should develop into an exploration of **why** this has been used, and the reasons the poet wants to slow or increase pace. The word "why" has been used a lot in this paragraph. That's because analysis means asking yourself **why** a writer has created a certain effect.

Writer's methods

This section is organised into: form, structure, and language. The poetry question in the CIE Literature for English exam wants you to consider all three as "writer's methods". This is because a poet uses all three to create meaning or convey ideas. Consider things like the poet's choice of form and perspective, its rhythm, rhyme, and tone of voice, and imagery.

Examiners require you to focus on the **poem's deeper ideas**, and in a sensitive way. To do this, you can discuss how the poet's methods reveal their aim or purpose. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Katherine Philips' intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

The poem is presented in an ordered form through which to give her advice to all women. This allows her to present a rational speaker, one who has formed her strong and controversial opinions on marriage based on reason and logic.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem's tight, sixteen line stanza presents a controlled and disciplined speaker who addresses an implicit, female listener, "Madam"	Philips subverts traditional attitudes that women are emotional and irrational by constructing a convincing voice with which to criticise seventeenth century social norms

Structure

In 'A Married State', Katherine Philips uses a sophisticated structure to present a scathing attack on traditional ideas of marriage.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Romantic relationships	The poem is in strict iambic pentameter and made up of rhyming couplets throughout	Philips' speaker is authoritative and calm in order to present the benefits of avoiding marriage, and to empower unmarried women to remain so

Language

Katherine Philips uses sophisticated imagery to highlight contrasts between married life and unmarried life.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Romantic relationships	The poet uses alliteration to draw attention to key ideas, such as in "crowned with much content", and "Turn, turn apostate to love's levity", ending the poem with a metaphor alluding to "hell"	Philips avoids elaborate imagery as the poem is a rational argument but, at times, a passionate speaker alludes to classical images that contrast the bliss of staying single with the shallowness and misery of romantic love

Understanding the text

The poetry questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an **informed, personal response**, which means that it is not enough just to know the poem, but that you will also need to develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events** to explore the writer's intentions and methods. This section has been divided into two main themes that Katherine Philips examines in her poem 'A Married State':

- Individual identity
- Romantic relationships



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward an answer that responds "sensitively and in considerable detail" to the way the writer achieves their effects. You are being asked to explore the poem beyond surface meanings to show deeper awareness of ideas and attitudes. For example, while knowing about seventeenth century attitudes to marriage, or Katherine Philips' own circumstances, will help you understand the debates she raises, your points must always be closely linked to the themes in the poem and relevant to the focus of the question, rather than simply listed as factual information.

Individual identity

- Katherine Philips is a highly respected and influential seventeenth century British poet and writer
- Philips' poetry is known for its sophisticated, classical styles:
 - Her poem 'A Married State', written in the late 1640s-1650s, adheres to traditional poetic techniques
- As much of her work examines the female experience, she is considered to be an early feminist writer
- The poem 'A Married State' can be considered a cautionary message
- The poem challenges typically idealised female roles, such as its suggestion that motherhood is best avoided:
 - Philips alludes to seventeenth century conditions for women, including painful and, often, fatal childbirth

Romantic relationships

- Katherine Philips' seventeenth century poem, 'A Married State', is a challenge to gender imbalances that, the poem argues, manifest in dysfunctional marriages
- She alludes to the way marriage is considered to be a Christian institution:
 - The poem refers to the way unmarried women were perceived as wild and dangerous; a myth, she says, that was designed to force them into marriage
- At the time, marriage amongst all but the lower classes could provide security and status; a financial contract that can improve social standing:
 - Often, a young girl was married to a much older man
- As women were not allowed any financial or personal independence, this led to power imbalances:
 - The poem alludes to the limited power of wives: they are fearful of abusive husbands and fake their happiness to avoid retribution
 - The controversial nature of Philips' poem is evident in the line "Turn, turn, apostate"
 - This suggests unmarried women are traitors for abandoning social norms

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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Your notes

From 'An Essay on Man'

Here is a detailed guide to Alexander Pope's poem 'From "An Essay on Man"', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line "translation" of the poem's meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods:** an exploration of Pope's poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Pope's poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Alexander Pope's intention and message

From "An Essay on Man" overview

The extracted poem is taken from 'An Essay on Man', a longer poem. In it, Alexander Pope debates the contradictions and weaknesses of human beings. He suggests that there is so much to learn about the experience of being human, we should concern ourselves with this before we try to understand the mysteries of religion.

From 'An Essay on Man' breakdown

Lines 1–2



"Know then thyself, presume not God to scan;
The proper study of mankind is man."

Translation

- The poem begins with an **omniscient narrator** offering a listener advice:
 - Humans should "know" themselves before expecting to understand "God"
- The narrator declares that the right thing to "study" is human nature

Pope's intentions

- The poem begins with an imperative command, creating an assertive voice
- An emphatic statement is given: it is arrogant to "presume" to study religion when human beings do not understand themselves

Lines 3–6



"Placed on this isthmus of a middle state,
A being darkly wise, and rudely great:
With too much knowledge for the sceptic side,
With too much weakness for the stoic's pride,"

Translation

- The narrator describes human beings as in a "middle" place, a narrow island
- The poet says there is a contradiction in human beings:
 - Humans are so "wise" they have lost all doubt ("sceptic")
 - This makes them "rudely great"
 - But they do not have enough wisdom to be resilient and unemotional ("stoic")

Pope's intentions

- Pope describes the earth as an "isthmus", perhaps suggesting a kind of purgatory
- He suggests human beings may be wise, but they are prideful with it, and this makes them weak

Lines 7–9



"He hangs between; in doubt to act, or rest;
In doubt to deem himself a god or beast,
In doubt his mind or body to prefer,"

Translation

- The narrator describes the doubt human beings experience
- This makes them seem like they are hanging between action and inaction
- They do not know if they are good or bad ("god, or beast")
- There is doubt, too, about whether they value their "mind or body"

Pope's intentions

- Pope highlights human weaknesses with a repetition of "doubt" and a list of the decisions humans are unsure about, emphasising his assertion

Lines 10–13



"Born but to die, and reasoning but to err;
Alike in ignorance, his reason such,
Whether he thinks too little or too much:
Chaos of thought and passion, all confused;"

Translation

- The narrator explains that humans are mortal, and whenever they try to reason, they make a mistake
- Humans are all ignorant ("alike") in this way: they overthink things or they do not plan enough but, either way, their thoughts are confused by emotion ("passion")

Pope's intentions

- Pope criticises the chaotic way humans reason and try to make decisions by presenting human behaviour as two extreme positions
- This proves his point that humans should better understand their motivations and accept their limitations

Lines 14–16



"Still by himself abused, or disabused;
Created half to rise and half to fall,
Great lord of all things, yet a prey to all;"

Translation

- Pope's narrator says that humans abuse themselves, are easily persuaded, and it is inevitable that some will succeed and others will fail
- Humans are powerful, "lord of all things", but they are also easy "prey" to everyone and everything

Pope's intentions

- The persuasive voice offers two opposing ideas in **parallelism** like "half to rise, and half to fall"
- Pope uses **juxtaposition** to show how individuals assume positions of power ("lord") but are, in fact, vulnerable "prey", which implies delusions of grandeur

Lines 17–18



"Sole judge of truth, in endless error hurled:
The glory, jest, and riddle of the world!"

Translation

- The poem ends by describing human beings as unable to understand the truth
- In summation, humans are a puzzle, a constant source of mockery, but also glorious

Pope's intentions

- Pope's poem ends with an exclamation and an emphatic triple to summarise his argument that suggests human understanding of the world is flawed and unpredictable



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Sometimes a writer's choice of structure and form overlap in terms of the effect or meaning they create. In your response to the poetry question, it is best to start your paragraphs with a point of analysis (an interpretation or argument statement), such as "Pope examines the inner turmoil of individuals exploring their identity." Then, support this statement with a close exploration of how aspects of form and/or structure and/or language reveal the speaker's attitudes.

Writer's methods

This section is organised into: form, structure, and language. The poetry question in the CIE Literature for English exam wants you to consider all three as "writer's methods". This is because a poet uses all three to create meaning or convey ideas. Consider things like the poet's choice of form and perspective, its rhythm, rhyme, and tone of voice, and imagery.

Examiners require you to focus on the **poem's deeper ideas**, and in a sensitive way. To do this you can discuss how the **poet's methods** reveal their **aim** or **purpose**. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Alexander Pope's intentions in terms of his choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Alexander Pope's from 'An Essay on Man' is a philosophical argument that is presented as advice to an implied listener.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem is constructed as one disciplined stanza to present a controlled speaker who directly addresses all individuals to "know thyself"	Pope's direct and authoritative narrator presents a debate on an individual's limitations, and urges the reader to study the human condition as a priority

Structure

Alexander Pope creates a calm and rational speaker's voice with which to present a classical debate on the contradictions of being human.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem is in strict iambic pentameter and made up of heroic couplets throughout	Pope's speaker sounds conversational and reflective, however the sophisticated structure elevates ideas in the poem

Language

Alexander Pope uses **paradox** to evaluate human nature. By juxtaposing descriptions, he concludes that humans are simply confusing, and this is why we should try to understand ourselves and our limitations before attempting even more complex theories like religion.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	The poem uses paradox throughout (such as in lines like "darkly wise, and rudely great"), as well as anaphora (like lines beginning "With too much"), ending the debate with a list of abstract nouns to sum up the confusing nature of human beings	Pope's poem intends to describe all individuals' contradictory and flawed thinking by highlighting inherent doubt and confusion

Understanding the text

The poetry questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an **informed, personal response**, which means that it is not enough just to know the poem, but that you will also need to develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events** to explore the writer's intentions and methods. This section has been divided into two main themes that Alexander Pope examines in his poem from 'An Essay on Man':

- Individual identity
- Cultural identity



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Writing an introduction can be tricky. Examiners are clear about what they are looking for, though. They reward essays that introduce a "personal and evaluative engagement". To do this, spend time thinking about the question before writing your answer. Ask yourself how the poet raises themes, and why they want their readers to consider these ideas. Often, the poet's aims are connected to the society in which they live, or their personal background. Examiners are clear that contextual information is to be used like this, as support for a personal interpretation.



Your notes

Individual identity

- Alexander Pope is a Neo-classical British poet, born in England in 1688 during the Augustan Age
- His poetry explores the individual experience, and the relationship between human beings and the universe, using logic and reasoned argument
- His epic work 'An Essay on Man', published in 1734, comprises four epistles:
 - In the poem, Pope presents the contradictory states of all human beings: the overarching sense of doubt, consistent mistakes, and mortality
 - The extract is often called 'Know then Thyself' or Epistle II
 - In Epistle II, he writes: "In doubt to deem himself a god, or beast; / In doubt his mind or body to prefer; / Born but to die, and reasoning but to err;"
- Although the work does not explicitly address any individual, it is said to have been written for a British politician and friend, St. John Lord Bolingbroke:
 - It starts "Awake, my St. John!"

Cultural identity

- Alexander Pope is highly respected for his philosophical works, such as 'An Essay on Man'
- Pope's work bears the influence of classical writers such as Lucretius, an ancient Roman writer and poet who explored the human condition:
 - Pope's poetry is said to have been influenced, too, by fellow Neo-classical poet John Milton, who wrote the epic poem Paradise Lost in 1667
- Pope lived under the social hierarchical system, the Divine Right of Kings:
 - The system advocates that the British monarch is chosen by God which, in terms of social ranking, places a king or queen directly under God, making them all powerful
- In Epistle II, Pope suggests that the humans are deluded to think they can be a "Great lord of all things":
 - He states that those who claim an understanding of God and believe they are capable of rational thought and truth are mistaken
 - He claims that all humans are ignorant, confused, and weak "prey"
 - He refers to power imbalances in the line "half to rise, and half to fall"

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

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‘Carpet-Weavers, Morocco’

Here is a detailed guide to Carol Rumens’ poem ‘Carpet-Weavers, Morocco’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods:** an exploration of Rumens’ poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Rumens’ poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Carol Rumens’ intention and message

‘Carpet-Weavers, Morocco’ overview

Carol Rumens’ poem depicts a speaker watching young people weaving carpets in Morocco. Rumens describes children focused on intricate work, and how the carpet they weave has a spiritual nature. The poem links an everyday practice for the children to their culture, religion and the world around them.

‘Capet-Weavers, Morocco’ breakdown

Line 1



“The children are at the loom of another world.”

Translation

- The poem begins with an **omniscient narrator** describing the concentrated activities of children weaving at a “loom”, a tool for weaving threads
- The narrator suggests they are transported to “another world”, as if daydreaming

Rumens’ intentions

- The poem introduces the children as mesmerised by their weaving, which brings a magical or mystical quality to the poem

Lines 2–3



“Their braids are oiled and black, their dresses bright.
Their assorted heights would make a melodious chime.”

Translation

- The narrator describes their hair and bright clothing
- The children are all different ages

Rumens’ intentions

- Rumens draws attention to the vivid and sensual appearance of the children:
 - She **juxtaposes** the darkness of the children’s hair with the bright colours of their clothes
 - This suggests there is beauty alongside mistreatment and darkness (of child labour)
- She compares their different heights to a tune made by different keys, suggesting the group works harmoniously

Lines 4–6



“They watch their flickering knots like television.
As the garden of Islam grows, the bench will be raised.

Then they will lace the dark-rose veins of the tree-tops."



Translation

- The narrator describes the way the children focus on weaving as if it was "television"
- The poet describes their carpet as a "garden of Islam", perhaps alluding to the designs of flowers and trees that the Moroccan children weave into the carpet
- As the carpet increases in size, they begin to move onto threading roses into the "treetops" (a design on the carpet)

Rumens' intentions

- The poet shows differences between two cultures through the Western reference to "television" and the Moroccan reference to "Islam"
- Rumens compares the carpet to a "garden of Islam" to suggest the carpet is an important part of the Islam tradition, as well as to describe the carpet's detail

Lines 7-9



"The carpet will travel in the merchant's truck.
It will be spread by the servants of the mosque.
Deep and soft, it will give when heaped with prayer."

Translation

- The narrator considers the future of the carpet, imaging how it will be taken by the "merchant" or carpet-seller, to a mosque
- It will be soft and comfortable when the many worshippers kneel on it to pray

Rumens' intentions

- Rumens links the carpet to religion, specifically Islam, and how the children's weaving has a deeper purpose
- The repetition of "will" suggests certainty, perhaps implying that the children are also trapped in a system that they cannot escape from
- She describes its significance with the [metaphor](#), "heaped with prayer"

Line 10



"The children are hard at work in the school of days."

Translation

- The narrator says that the children learn as they work and that, while they are not at school, they work hard

Rumens' intentions

- Rumens changes the traditional phrase "school days" to show the different lives of children who work instead of going to school
- There is an implication that their "hard at work" is a daily occurrence

Lines 11-12



"From their fingers the colours of all-that-will-be fly
and freeze into the frame of all-that-was."

Translation

- The poem ends by describing how the colours of the carpet appear to "fly" from the children's fast "fingers"
- The final line concludes that the carpets are a symbol of the future and the past

Rumens' intentions

- The poem ends with a metaphor that alludes to the children's skilful work
- The carpet under their masterful hands is like a "frame" or canvas that represents timeless cultural traditions



Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes and, specifically, the “deeper meanings of the poem”. Examiners advise you to spend more time thinking about, for example, the reason a poet raises certain themes. Sometimes, a poet raises themes and concerns about their own background or society. Other poets may wish to explore unfamiliar cultural identities and environments.



Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered “writer’s methods” in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet’s choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet’s overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Carol Rumens’ intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Rumens’ free-flowing rhythm and steady voice contributes to the reflective nature of the poem.

Theme	Evidence	Poet’s intention
Cultural identity	The poem’s free verse allows for a calm, reflective tone, but alliteration adds drama to the scene, such as in “fingers” and “fly, and in end-stopped lines that disrupt the poem’s fluidity	Rumens’ speaker appears entranced as they watch children weaving, yet there are hints at more salient thoughts, such as references to “television”, “merchant’s trucks”, and “school of days”

Structure

Carol Rumens structures the poem into regular three line **stanzas** that progress through an omniscient narrator’s observations and thoughts.

Theme	Evidence	Poet’s intention
Cultural identity	The poem is constructed as four tercets which describe a Moroccan carpet as it is presently, and as it will be in the future	Rumens’ poem describes the children who weave a Moroccan carpet, and reflects on the timeless significance of the carpet as a symbol of cultural identity
		The poem looks regular and carefully crafted, just as the carpet is.
	The poet uses enjambment in the final line	This symbolises the leap across time that the lines describe

Language

Carol Rumens uses vivid **imagery** to describe the beauty of the carpets the children weave. She makes allusions to the sacred place the carpets hold in Islam tradition.

Theme	Evidence	Poet’s intention
Cultural identity	The metaphor, “loom of another world” alludes to the spiritual qualities of the carpet, while the “garden of Islam” and “dark-rose veins” brings the carpet to life as if a living thing that will soon be “heaped with prayers”	Rumens emphasises the intricate detail of carpets weaved in Morocco, and highlights their spiritual significance across time, in “all-that-will-be” and “all-that-was”

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem’s themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore the writer’s intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes that Carol Rumens explores in her poem ‘Carpet-Weavers, Morocco’:

- Cultural identity



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Writing an introduction can be tricky. Examiners are clear about what they are looking for, though. They reward essays that introduce a “personal and evaluative engagement”. To do this, spend time thinking about the question before writing your answer. Ask yourself how the poet raises themes, and why they want their readers to consider these ideas. Often, the poet’s aims are connected to the society in which they live, or their personal background. Examiners ask that you use contextual information like this, as support for a personal interpretation.



Cultural identity

- Carol Rumens is a British poet born in 1947:
 - Her work often explores foreign cultures, histories and traditions
- In Rumens' poem, 'Carpet-Weavers, Morocco', she considers the lives of children who work as carpet-weavers day after day:
 - She contrasts them with children who watch “television” and go to school
 - The poem draws attention to the “hard work” they complete day after day
- This poem raises the profile of the culture and traditions of Morocco:
 - In the poem a narrator, clearly unfamiliar with the strange weaving of Moroccan carpets, is fascinated by their skill and focus
 - Rumens examines the significance of the carpet in Moroccan culture
 - A “merchant” will take it to a “mosque”
 - It must be soft for the worshipper’s knees when it becomes “heaped with prayer”

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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‘Sonnet 18’

Here is a detailed guide to William Shakespeare's poem 'Sonnet 18', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line "translation" of the poem's meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods:** an exploration of Shakespeare's poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Shakespeare's poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining William Shakespeare's intention and message

‘Sonnet 18’ overview

William Shakespeare's 'Sonnet 18' argues for the power of love, and art such as poetry, to transcend the limits of time. The speaker raises a question about a loved one's appearance, and concludes that true love lasts despite the passing of time or the fading of looks.

‘Sonnet 18’ breakdown

Lines 1–2



"Shall I compare thee to a summer's day
Thou art more lovely and more temperate:"

Translation

- The poem begins with a question to an implied listener, a loved one, "thee"
- The speaker says that if they were to compare their loved one to a "summer's day", the comparison would be poor, because a "summer's day" is not as "lovely" or pleasant

Shakespeare's intentions

- Shakespeare begins his [sonnet](#) in a traditionally romantic style
- The [hyperbolic](#) "more lovely and more temperate" resonates with typically sentimental romantic poetry that praises beauty and a calm nature

Lines 3–6



"Rough winds do shake the darling buds of May,
And summer's lease hath all too short a date:
Sometime too hot the eye of heaven shines
And often is his gold complexion dimmed;"

Translation

- The speaker describes a "summer's day" as less than ideal, explaining why their loved one is "more temperate":
 - In "May", heavy "winds" shake all the budding flowers from the trees
 - Summer is too short
 - Sometimes the sun ("eye of heaven") is "too hot" and, at other times, the sun's "gold" face is not bright, perhaps "dimmed" by cloud

Shakespeare's intentions

- Shakespeare's speaker acknowledges that the usual romantic descriptions are lacking and mostly invalid, which challenges sentimental notions of love:
 - For this speaker, his beloved is the height of beauty, rather than a summer's day

Lines 7–8



"And every fair from fair sometime declines,
By chance, or nature's changing course, untrimmed;"

Translation

- The speaker adds that everything that is "fair" or attractive loses its beauty
- Sometimes one's appearance "declines" by bad luck, or simply the inevitable passing of time

Shakespeare's intentions

- Shakespeare's sonnet attempts an accurate portrayal of beauty: all beautiful things, he suggests, are naturally temporary

Lines 9–12



"But thy eternal summer shall not fade,
Nor lose possession of that fair thou ow'st;
Nor shall death brag thou wander'st in his shade,
When in eternal lines to time thou grow'st:"

Translation

- The speaker then says that their loved one is different:
 - Their "summer", their pleasant nature, is "eternal"
 - They will never lose the "fair" (attractiveness) they own
 - They will never get weak or unattractive over time ("death" will not "brag" at them becoming frail and wrinkled with "eternal lines")

Shakespeare's intentions

- Shakespeare uses the [metaphor](#) of an "eternal summer" to describe their loved one as forever young and attractive in their eyes
- The poem advocates for a love that does not alter over time, or when beauty fades:
 - Shakespeare might also be suggesting that this poem will also live on

Lines 13–14



"So long as men can breathe, or eyes can see
So long lives this, and this gives life to thee."

Translation

- The speaker concludes that as long as human beings "breathe" and can "see", their argument remains true, like their love
- The poem, the speaker says, makes this true forever, and "gives life", or immortalises, the listener

Shakespeare's intentions

- Shakespeare's sonnet ends on a [rhyming couplet](#) that sums up the ideas in the poem: the truth held within the poem, like the speaker's love, will last forever



Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes and, specifically, the "deeper meanings of the poem". Examiners advise you to spend more time thinking about, for example, the reason a poet raises certain themes. Sometimes, a poet raises themes and concerns about their own background or society. Other poets may wish to explore unfamiliar cultural identities and environments.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes William Shakespeare's intentions in terms of his choices of:



- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Shakespeare's 'Sonnet 18' uses the traditional form of a 14-line sonnet to speak directly to a loved one. However, the poem offers an alternative perspective to romance as it takes the form of an argument.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Romantic love	Typically for a sonnet, a turning point comes after the first eight lines, but Shakespeare alters the form of a Petrarchan sonnet to add an additional volta after line twelve to introduce a final summation about the everlasting nature of true love	Shakespeare's sonnets often use a final rhyming couplet to present a conclusive and emphatic wisdom, which deviates from classically sentimental sonnets

Structure

Shakespeare uses the disciplined structure of a sonnet to present a controlled speaker, one whose love is pure and eternal, not a temporary passion.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Romantic love	The poem's iambic pentameter and regular, alternating rhyme scheme is typical for a sonnet, lending itself to traditional romantic ideals	Shakespeare uses a steady rhythm and sophisticated metre to emphasise the steadfast and constant nature of true love

Language

Shakespeare describes love in terms of a season, "summer", to introduce the transient nature of beauty and, thus, love should not be based on superficial appearance.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Romantic love	The poem's speaker uses natural imagery to expose the unpredictability of nature (there are "rough winds", summer is short, and the sun can be "too hot"), as well as to symbolise the physical changes that occur over time, but then goes on to describe the "eternal summer" of their loved one	Shakespeare's 'Sonnet 18' suggests that superficial love is like "summer", less than ideal and temporary, but asserts that true love is found in an individual's pleasant nature, which will never "fade"

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore the writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into the main theme that William Shakespeare explores in his poem 'Sonnet 18':

- Romantic love



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Writing an introduction can be tricky. Examiners are clear about what they are looking for, though. They reward essays that introduce a "personal and evaluative engagement". To do this, spend time thinking about the question before writing your answer. Ask yourself how the poet raises themes, and why they want their readers to consider these ideas. Often, the poet's aims are connected to the society in which they live, or their personal background. Examiners ask that you use contextual information like this, as support for a personal interpretation.

Romantic love

- William Shakespeare wrote a collection of sonnets in the late sixteenth century:
 - The sonnets often use natural imagery and the weather to show the impermanence of life, or to compare to the constancy of nature
- In 'Sonnet 18' Shakespeare's "summer's day" is presented as a weak comparison for their lover as it is unpredictable and short:
 - The poet later concludes that an "eternal summer" can be found in one's personality or "temperament"



- 'Sonnet 18' alludes to humanist ideas rather than traditional notions of fated love:
 - Instead of being obsessive and in turmoil about love, individuals should practise self-control and assert their free will
 - It concludes "So long as men can breathe or eyes can see/So long lives this", which immortalises the poet's words, and their love
- Shakespearean sonnets are slightly different to the sonnets written by Italian poet Petrarch in the early part of the sixteenth century:
 - These early sonnets were written by aristocrats and tended to be about forbidden and lustful affairs, or beautiful and unavailable women
- Shakespeare's sonnets subvert traditional overly sentimental poetry and offer alternative perspectives on romantic love:
 - In this sonnet, he advocates for love that does not alter over time

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/414779-2020-specimen-mark-scheme-1.pdf>.

Songs of Ourselves: Volume 1: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Poetry in English. Cambridge University Press & Assessment, 2018.

‘Hunting Snake’

Here is a detailed guide to Judith Wright’s poem ‘Hunting Snake’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview:** a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods:** an exploration of Wright’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text:** an exploration of the themes and ideas within Wright’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Judith Wright’s intention and message

‘Hunting Snake’ overview

Judith Wright’s poem ‘Hunting Snake’ describes an encounter between two walkers and a snake that crosses its path. The poem reflects on the mixed emotions resulting from a brief sighting of a dangerous but beautiful predator in the wild.

‘Hunting Snake’ breakdown

Lines 1–3



“Sun-warmed in this late season’s grace
under the autumn’s gentlest sky
we walked, and froze half-through a pace.”

Translation

- The speaker describes the weather: it is a calm and a sunny “late” autumn day
- The speaker is walking with someone else, “we”, when they suddenly stop

Wright’s intentions

- The poet sets a harmonious and calm scene, full of “grace” under the “gentlest sky”
- This allows for an abrupt mood shift, as “sun-warmed” is contrasted with “froze”:
 - The fact that they froze halfway through their steps reinforces the idea of surprise; they were stopped in the middle of action

Line 4



“The great black snake went reeling by.”

Translation

- The speaker explains why they stopped walking: a large snake slides by

Wright’s intentions

- The **end-stopped line** conveys tension as a “great black snake” suddenly passes:
 - The word “black” suggests something evil or menacing, **juxtaposed** with “great” which suggests the watchers experience both fear and awe at the sight of the snake

Lines 5–7



“Head down, tongue flickering on the trail
he quested through the parting grass;
sun glazed his curves of diamond scale,”

Translation

- The next **stanza** describes the snake in detail:
 - Its tongue flicks across the path as he moves through the grass
- The sun shines on its "diamond" scales as it wriggles its body

Wright's intentions

- The snake is described with **imagery** that suggests its beauty and strength
- The snake's movements are determined ("head down", it "quested"):
 - A "quest" suggests a noble cause, again reinforcing the mixed feelings of the speaker towards the snake
 - Imagery of precious gems, such as "glazed" and "diamond" implies both reverence and awe

Line 8



"and we lost breath to watch him pass."

Translation

- As they watch the snake, the speaker and companion become breathless

Wright's intentions

- Again, Wright ends a stanza by turning from a description of nature back to the speaker and their companion's reactions
- The poet describes the experience of seeing a wild animal as moving, which highlights the power of nature

Lines 9–10



"What track he followed, what small food
fled living from his fierce intent,"

Translation

- The speaker wonders about where the snake is going, and if it is hunting a small animal that has run ("fled") from the snake's "fierce" intention, which is to eat it

Wright's intentions

- Wright's speaker turns inward as they imagine the snake as a frightening predator
- The poem depicts an individual reflecting on the life of a wild animal:
 - The speaker conveys the power of the snake via its "fierce intent"

Lines 11–12



"we scarcely thought; still as we stood
our eyes went with him as he went."

Translation

- The speaker and their companion are transfixed by the snake
- Although the sighting of the snake is brief, the speaker and their companion are entranced

Wright's intentions

- Wright shows the mixed reactions of humans coming into contact with a dangerous, predatory animal:
 - They are in awe, but there is also a sense of fear (they stand "still")

Lines 13–16



"Cold, dark and splendid he was gone
into the grass that hid his prey.
We took a deeper breath of day,
looked at each other, and went on."



Translation

- The snake is described as dangerous, yet majestic and beautiful
- The snake goes into the grass to hunt small animals
- At this, the speaker and their companion take a deep breath and acknowledge the moment by looking at "each other" before they continue their walk

Wright's intentions

- Wright returns to the imagery used to describe the snake at the start of the poem
- Wright's description of the observers' breathlessness at seeing the snake alludes to both their own fear, and the profound effect of seeing nature up close:
 - The subtle mention of the look the speaker shares with their walking companion connotes to a mixed sense of relief and wonder



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme, you are rewarded when you show an understanding of the deeper meanings of the poem. To do this, you should try to explore aspects of form and/or structure and/or language, and how the poet's choices reveal attitudes. For example, you could start your essay paragraphs with a point or interpretation, such as "Wright draws attention to the power of nature in her description of a snake crossing a walker's path." Then, support this argument, not just with a quote, but with an analysis of the writer's methods.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Judith Wright's intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Judith Wright's poem 'Hunting Snake' uses a regular, steady form that reveals each unfolding event as walkers stop to watch a snake cross their trail.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	The poem has four regular quatrains that progress through the speaker's experience in alternating rhyming lines	The poem is a steady and ordered form that mimics the speaker's contemplation about their own reactions to nature

Structure

Wright's poem conveys the mixed reactions of humans seeing a wild, predatory snake.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	Lines that describe the snake use enjambment to mimic the speaker's breathlessness, but caesura and end-stopped lines present a tense and captivated speaker	Wright reflects the awe and fear the speaker feels as they spot a "splendid" snake, highlighting the power of nature to affect ordinary people on a walk

Language

In 'Hunting Snake', Judith Wright uses vivid imagery that highlights the beauty of nature, alongside emotive language that conveys the human being's response to it.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	The poem contrasts the "grace" of a "sun-warmed", gentle "sky" with the "cold, dark and splendid", yet "fierce" snake	Wright presents the strange, often contradictory, relationship between humans and nature, highlighting both the pleasure of an autumn walk and the ill-ease brought about by an encounter with a wild animal

Understanding the text

The poetry questions in the CIE Literature for English exam ask for an **informed, personal response**. This means that you will want to develop a **thorough understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events** so that you can explore the writer's intentions and methods. This section explores the main theme that Judith Wright conveys in her poem 'Hunting Snake':

- Humans and nature



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward an answer that responds "sensitively and in considerable detail" to the way the writer achieves their effects. You are being asked to explore the poem beyond surface meanings to show deeper awareness of ideas and attitudes. So, your points should always be closely linked to the themes in the poem and relevant to the focus of the question, rather than simply listed as factual information.

Humans and nature

- Judith Wright was born in 1915 in Australia:
 - She was a poet, short-story writer, conservationist and campaigner for Aboriginal Australian land rights
- She was a founder of The Wildlife Preservation Society of Queensland
- Her poetry often describes Australia's natural environment:
 - In her poem, 'Hunting Snake', she shows the "grace" of an autumn day, and a "splendid" snake that moves "head-down, tongue flickering on the trail"
- Australia has over a hundred species of snake:
 - The snake described in Wright's poem is likely poisonous
 - It is described as "fierce" and after small "prey"
- In addition, Wright's poetry often covers themes that explore global and societal pressures on individuals, as well as ideas of identity and belonging:
 - Her poetry often uses a controlled voice with sensory, lyrical descriptions
- In 'Hunting Snake', a poem published in 1964, Wright describes the snake with sensory imagery:
 - Yet lines that mention the speaker's response are straightforward, like "looked at each other, and went on."
- Her writing often examines profound moments in life:
 - Her poem, 'Hunting Snake', contemplates the moment a pair of walkers "freeze" and become transfixed with a brief observation of a snake

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: [what the question is asking](#) and [how to get full marks](#). You will also find an example of a full, annotated [model answer](#).

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<https://www.uwa.edu.au/news/article/2022/may/judith-wright-an-activist-poet-who-was-ahead-of-her-time>.